

3-YEAR-OLD 'ASSAULTED' AT
PLAYSCHOOL; FOUR BOOKED **P2**



PUNJAB: AAP LEADER GURPREET
GOPI SHOT DEAD IN FEROZEPUR **P5**

PRATIK OPENS UP ABOUT
BOX OFFICE PRESSURE **P12**



India and Uzbekistan upgrade ties, seal uranium deal, eye \$5 bn trade

Modi calls Uzbekistan central to India's Central Asia engagement

MPOST BUREAU
Tashkent, August 30

India and Uzbekistan elevated their bilateral relationship to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership on Sunday following talks between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Uzbek President Shavkat Mirziyoyev.

Marking the 15th anniversary of the strategic partnership, the two nations set a target of \$5 billion in annual trade by 2030 and agreed to establish a framework for long-term uranium supply from Uzbekistan to India, among other things.

PM Modi confirmed that India and Uzbekistan would establish a long-term uranium supply arrangement, a move expected to help keep India's nuclear power plans on track for the long haul.



PM Narendra Modi receives Uzbekistan's 'Oliy Darajali Do'stlik' award from President Shavkat Mirziyoyev in Tashkent

PTI

"We will also establish a long-term arrangement

for the supply of uranium," PM Modi said, flagging it

KEY POINTS

- » Uranium deal supports India's nuclear ambitions
- » Bilateral trade crossed \$1 billion last year
- » Joint ventures increased sevenfold
- » Fourteen weekly direct flights connect both countries
- » Eleven agreements signed across key sectors
- » Defence co-development and co-production to expand
- » Critical minerals cooperation to deepen
- » Mining and mineral processing partnerships planned
- » Indian firms invited to explore Uzbek mineral deposits

as one of the biggest take-aways from the talks.

Modi conferred with Uzbek's highest honour

Tashkent, August 30

Prime Minister Narendra Modi was on Sunday conferred with Uzbekistan's highest honour for foreign leaders, the 'Oliy Darajali Do'stlik' Order, which he dedicated to the "enduring" bond between New Delhi and Tashkent.

The Uzbek honour adds to a list of top state and civilian awards conferred on Modi by close to three dozen countries in recognition

India and Uzbekistan are also

CONTINUED ON P4

Nepal flood toll rises to 788; over 275 Indians remain untraceable

Rising water level in Bhotekoshi renews fears

MPOST BUREAU

Kathmandu, August 30

The death toll from the devastating flash floods that struck Nepal on August 26 rose to 788 on Sunday, as rescue teams continued recovering bodies from flood-hit areas and authorities warned of a fresh rise in water levels in the Bhotekoshi River.

More than 2,500 people remain missing in Nepal, while nearly 9,500 people have been rescued from affected districts, according to the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRMA). Authorities have urged residents as well as rescue personnel to remain alert amid intermittent rainfall and the possibility of further flooding.

The disaster is believed to have been triggered by a collapse or avalanche of ice and rock near the Nepal-Tibet border. The resulting floodwaters moved



People carrying relief material move to a safer place in Galchhi, Dhading district, Nepal

PTI

CLOSER LOOKS

- » Over 275 Indians and 128 persons of Indian origin remain missing
- » MEA released a list of 149 Indians rescued from Nepal
- » India sent 18 forensic experts to help identify victims through DNA
- » An 11-member Indian team joined Nepal's tunnel rescue operations
- » India provided 68.5 tonnes of relief materials to flood-hit Nepal

downstream through the Bhotekoshi River, causing widespread destruction across towns and villages

in northern and central Nepal. Homes, vehicles, roads and bridges were swept

CONTINUED ON P4

CELEBRATION AHEAD



People carry an idol of Lord Ganesh to a pandal ahead of the Ganesh Chaturthi festival in Mumbai on Sunday

PTI

SC to hear today plea against cash donations received by pol parties

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 30

The Supreme Court is set to hear on Monday a petition challenging a provision of the Income Tax Act, 1961, that permits political parties to accept anonymous cash donations of less than Rs 2,000.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta is likely to take up the matter, according to

the court's cause list. The Supreme Court had earlier issued notices to the Centre, the Election Commission and other parties seeking their responses to the petition.

The plea, filed by Khem Singh Bhati, challenges Clause (d) of Section 13A of the Income Tax Act, which provides special tax treatment to political parties. It argues that allowing cash contributions

CONTINUED ON P4

180-DAY WINDOW FOR COMPLIANCE

New rules mandate IST as single official time across India

NARESH BISWANI
New Delhi, August 30

The government has notified new rules making Indian Standard Time (IST) the single reference for legal, administrative, commercial and other official activities across the country.

The Legal Metrology (Indian Standard Time) Rules, 2026 were notified by the Consumer Affairs Ministry on August 27. However, they will take effect 180 days after publication in the official gazette, allowing government departments, businesses and institutions time to update their systems.

The move comes as banking, digital payments, telecommunications, railways, power grids and computer networks increasingly depend on accurate and synchronised timestamps. The ministry said differences between time sources currently being used could affect the coordination and recording of such activities.

Under the new framework, a common time

reference will support timestamping of financial and digital payment transactions, coordination of railways, airports and other transport networks, telecommunications and internet services, power systems, government and legal records, as well as emergency and other time-sensitive operations.

The rules also seek to reduce reliance on foreign satellite-based timing sources used by some critical systems. The government is developing infrastructure through Indian institutions and legal metrology laboratories to distribute accurate IST.

The framework permits the use

CONTINUED ON P4

HIGHLIGHT

- » India supplied up to 1 million barrels of petrol to Russia over the past two months
- » Russian gasoline imports hit a record 125,000 bpd in August, or about 470,000 tonnes

Vadinar refinery in Gujarat, operated by Nayara Energy, which is 50 per cent owned by Russian oil major Rosneft.

The growing fuel trade comes as India has sharply increased its purchases of Russian

CONTINUED ON P4



सुरक्षा और निवेश बोर्ड
Securities and Exchange Board of India



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REFINERY ATTACKS DISRUPT FUEL SUPPLIES

India emerges as key petrol supplier to Russia

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, August 30

India has become a major supplier of petrol to Russia as repeated Ukrainian drone attacks on Russian refineries have disrupted domestic fuel production and pushed Moscow to seek more supplies from overseas, according to ship-tracking data and trade sources.

Russia's seaborne gasoline imports rose to a record level of about 125,000 barrels per day (kbd) in August, equivalent to an estimated 470,000 tonnes for the month,



energy analytics firm Vortexa said. The increase follows attacks that have damaged refining capacity and reduced the availability of petrol inside the country.

Indian refiners supplied up to 1 million barrels of gasoline to Russia over the past two months, according to trade sources. Most of the shipments originated from the

3-year-old ‘assaulted’ at playschool; four booked

School staff booked under POCSO, JJ Act...

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

New Delhi, August 30

A three-year-old boy, whose father is an advocate, was allegedly physically assaulted and tied to a chair for hours by a 35-year-old attendant at a playschool in Maujpur, northeast Delhi.

The incident came to light after the child’s parents noticed drastic changes in his behaviour and injuries on his body. The boy had allegedly become afraid of going to the washroom, remained agitated and cried for hours at night. His parents also noticed bruises on his face and arms.

Following a complaint by the child’s father, police registered an FIR at Jafraabad police station on Friday against four school officials – the director,

TAKEAWAYS

» The incident came to light after the child’s parents noticed drastic changes in his behaviour and injuries on his body

» The boy had allegedly become afraid of going to the washroom, remained agitated and cried for hours at night. His parents also noticed bruises on his face and arms

» Following a complaint by the child’s father, police registered an FIR at Jafraabad police station on Friday against four school officials – director, principal, teacher and attendant



principal, teacher and attendant.

The latter has been arrested, while the 30-year-old teacher has been asked to go under investigation. Police look into the involvement of the director and the principal in the abuse.

Police said the par-

ents took their son to an ENT specialist when they noticed his condition. Police said CCTV footage allegedly showed the toddler being pulled by his ears, tied to a chair, kicked and repeatedly hit. Medical examination found abrasions on his face and arms.

Ghaziabad: Couple killed as speeding truck drags motorcycle for 100 metres

DIPIKA KIROLA

Ghaziabad, August 30

A 36-year-old man and his wife were killed after their motorcycle was hit by a speeding truck on NH-9 near Chhijarsi Cut under Indirapuram police station limits on Sunday morning. The impact was so severe that the motorcycle became lodged in the front of the truck and was dragged for nearly 100 metres. The truck driver fled the spot, leaving the vehicle behind.

Police identified the deceased as Ashish Anand, a resident of Saya Gold Society in Indirapuram, and his wife Neelam, 32. The couple, originally from Baghpat, had married in March 2019. Ashish worked for a private company, while Neelam was a dietitian at a private hospital.

According to Neelam’s brother, Gaurav, the family had gathered at the couple’s home for Rakshabandhan. As Sunday



was a holiday, Ashish and Neelam had planned to go shopping and chose to take their motorcycle instead of their car to avoid traffic congestion.

“At around 11.15am, when they reached near Chhijarsi Cut, a speeding truck hit their motorcycle from behind. The bike got lodged in the truck’s front section and was dragged for a considerable distance. My sister and brother-in-law fell onto the road and came under the truck’s wheels,”

CLOSER LOOK

» ‘At around 11.15am, when they reached near Chhijarsi Cut, a speeding truck hit their motorcycle from behind. The bike got lodged in the truck’s front section and was dragged...’

» ‘My sister and brother-in-law fell onto the road and came under the truck’s wheels,’ Gaurav said

» Police informed the family about the accident, and both Ashish and Neelam died at the scene

» The couple’s five-year-old daughter, Ashvika, is currently staying with her maternal grandparents

Gaurav said.

Police informed the family about the accident, and both Ashish and Neelam died at the scene.

The couple’s five-year-old daughter, Ashvika, is currently staying with her maternal grandparents. The family has not yet told her that both her parents have died.

“We don’t know how to tell such a small child that her parents are no more,” Gaurav said.

Assistant Commissioner of Police, Indirapuram,

Suryabali Maurya said the bodies had been sent for post-mortem examination. The truck has been seized and police are trying to trace its driver and owner. They found that the vehicle was registered in Hoshiarpur, Punjab.

“Footage from CCTV cameras installed around the accident site is being collected to establish the sequence of events. A case will be registered and further action taken after the family submits a complaint,” the ACP said.

Delhi Police’s ‘Operation Chakra’ leads to 193 arrests

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, August 30

Delhi Police has arrested 193 people and registered 154 cases under various laws during a 72-hour crackdown against criminals under ‘Operation Chakra’ in the North district, officials said on Sunday.

The operation was conducted from August 24 to 27. Police teams

from various police stations and units carried out checking, patrolling, searches and surveillance at strategic locations during the drive targeting illicit liquor, drugs, illegal arms and gambling.

According to the police, 63 people were arrested under the Excise Act and 10,122 bottles of illicit liquor and a car were seized.



Under the NDPS Act,

21 people were arrested and 1.975 kg of ganja, 39.2 grams of heroin, 544 grams of charas, 240 buprenorphine tablets and 500 Avil injections.

The operation also led to the arrest of 22 people under the Arms Act and recovery of 22 knives, three country-made pistols and two live cartridges.

In gambling-related cases, 87 people were arrested and Rs 1.69 lakh, two mobile phones and playing cards were seized. Fifty cases were registered under the Gambling Act.

Four stolen two-wheelers were also recovered during the operation. Further action is underway, they added.

Couple suffers 60% burns

New Delhi, August 30

Two persons suffered burn injuries after an LPG cylinder exploded at a jhuggi in Delhi’s Vivek Vihar here on Sunday, an official of the Delhi Fire Service said.

The injured were identified as Anil Das (35), and his wife Khushboo (30); both sustained around 60 per cent burn injuries, he said.

According to the Delhi Fire Service, a call regard-

ing an LPG cylinder fire was received at 4.24 pm from jhuggi located behind Vivek Vihar police station.

Two water tenders and one water bowser were rushed to the spot following the information, he said. The fire was brought under control by 4.55pm. The injured were taken to Rajiv Gandhi Hospital in a PCR vehicle, while details of the blast remained awaited. MPST

Briefs

4 Himanshu Bhau syndicate members held

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police’s Special Cell arrested four alleged members of the Himanshu Bhau syndicate from Kota, including wanted criminals Raman alias Fauji, 19, and Karan, 22.

The duo was wanted in multiple murder, attempted murder and firing cases across Delhi, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh. Brothers Shekher and Vinod Tiwari were arrested for allegedly sheltering them and acting as money mules.

Ex-DTC bus driver convicted

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court convicted former DTC bus driver Karan Singh for rash and negligent driving that caused the death of Amit Singh in 2021. The court found Singh rammed his bus into a two-wheeler from behind during peak morning hours, crushing the rider under its rear tyre. It rejected his defence that the bus was not involved, citing eyewitness and technical evidence, including blood and flesh recovered from the tyre. The court held that he failed to slow down or brake in time despite driving a larger vehicle. Sentence arguments will be heard Monday.

Alka Lamba’s father’s Delhi home burgled

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, August 30

Congress leader Alka Lamba’s father’s home in west Delhi’s Tagore Garden was allegedly burgled, with three masked men breaking into the house and escaping with cash and jewellery, police said on Sunday.

The incident was captured on a CCTV camera installed at the property, with the footage showing masked men entering the premises and later, fleeing on a motorcycle.

The footage has since gone viral on social media platforms.

According to officials, the incident took place in C-Block, Tagore Garden, under the Rajouri Garden police station area.

A case has been registered in this connection and police are scanning the CCTV footage collected from the premises and surrounding areas to trace the suspects.

Lamba said three masked men entered her father’s Tagore Garden home, stole Rs 1.75 lakh and jewellery, and fled on a motorcycle.

Police registered an FIR and are examining CCTV footage to trace them.

After trader-vendor dispute, MCD clears encroachments

ANAMTA FATIMA

New Delhi, August 30

A day after a dispute between shopkeepers and street vendors, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) carried out an anti-encroachment drive in the Teliwara area of Sadar Bazaar, targeting unauthorised structures and roadside obstructions in the busy commercial hub.

The drive was conducted by the Maintenance and Licensing Department of the MCD’s City-Sadar Paharganj Zone, with a heavy police presence. MCD teams used bulldozers to remove tin sheds, kiosks and other unauthorised constructions out-

side around 15-20 shops in the area, including along Kutub Road.

The action followed an altercation involving street vendors and traders, including Pratap Market local shopkeepers. In protest, traders had shut Pratap Market for several hours. The Federation of Sadar Bazaar Traders Association (FESTA) subsequently sought intervention from senior police and civic officials.

Mixed response

While some traders welcomed the removal of the structures, several shopkeepers expressed dissatisfaction with the manner of the operation. They

alleged that the drive was conducted without prior information and claimed that some shop shutters were damaged during the removal process.

Traders also raised allegations of civic officials taking “commissions” from street vendors, though these claims could not be independently verified. Also some vendors politely asked CM Rekha Gupta and agreeing to their mistakes that yes we agree on the encroachment part but give us prior notice. MCD said it was taking stringent action against encroachments across Delhi. Traders said sustained enforcement was needed to address congestion.

DUSU 2026 CAMPAIGN SHIFTS TO SOCIAL MEDIA

Reels, memes replace posters

ANAMTA FATIMA

New Delhi, August 30

The walls of Delhi University may be quieter this election season, but the campaign is far from subdued. With the university enforcing strict rules against defacement, the DUSU 2026 contest is increasingly playing out on phone screens, where reels, memes, music and carefully packaged political messages are competing for the attention of students.

The Delhi University Students’ Union election is scheduled for September 18, with counting on September 19. As the formal electoral process approaches, student organisations are turning social media into their new campaign ground – replacing posters and graffiti with Instagram reels, short vid-



eos and digital outreach.

The campaign has already acquired the familiar DUSU flavour: large car convoys making their way towards campuses, candidates posing for reels against Punjabi and Haryanvi tracks, and carefully edited videos designed to project both popularity and personality. For candidates chasing the first-time voter, however, the

pitch is increasingly about college-specific concerns, packaged through a mix of serious questions, humour and trend-driven content.

The shift is partly driven by the university’s stringent defacement guidelines. The election notification specifically places the Lyngdoh Committee recommendations, the Delhi Prevention of Defacement of Property Act, 2007, and relevant

FOR CANDIDATES CHASING THE FIRST-TIME VOTER, HOWEVER, THE PITCH IS INCREASINGLY ABOUT COLLEGE-SPECIFIC CONCERNS...

Delhi High Court and NGT directions within the framework governing the polls.

Yet moving online has not taken the politics out of the campaign. If anything, it has made the contest more immediate and more performative.

The traditional ABVP-NSUI face-off remains central to the DUSU battle, while Left organisations such as AISA and SFI are seeking to

expand their presence. The Aam Aadmi Party’s student wing, Association of Students for Alternative Politics (ASAP), is also attempting to carve out space, including by highlighting its role in recent student mobilisation and the Jantar Mantar movement. The official process begins with September 10, the last date for filing nominations, along with a Rs 500 demand draft and affidavits. Scrutiny and publication of nominated candidates will follow the same day, while withdrawals close on September 11.

Voting will take place in two shifts – 8.30 am to 1 pm for day classes and 3 pm to 7.30 pm for evening classes.

This year, the campaign may have fewer walls to write on. But there are millions of screens to reach.

22-year-old found dead

New Delhi, August 30

A 22-year-old woman was found dead inside the bathroom of her house in outer-north Delhi’s Prahlapur Bangar village, following which a case has been registered and police launched a search for her husband, an official said on Sunday.

The deceased was identified as Sabila Khatun, wife of Mohammad Lalbabu, who had been living with her husband at Prahlapur Bangar. The couple had been married for around two years, he said.

According to the police, information regarding the woman’s death was received at Shahbad Dairy police station on

August 29.

A police team reached the house, where the woman was found lying dead inside the bathroom.

Sabila’s brother, Mohammad Gulab, subsequently approached the police and informed them about the incident.

The complainant told police that when he reached his sister’s house, he found her dead while her husband and child were missing from the premises.

Police said the woman’s death was under investigation and an FIR had been registered. Her body was preserved at BSA Hospital for post-mortem. Efforts are underway to trace her husband, police said. MPST

Delhi Police takes up over 1,500 grievances

Weekly public hearings

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, August 30

Delhi Police took up 1,561 complaints and grievances during its weekly “Thana Divas - Jansunwai” public hearing sessions held across all 15 police districts, officials said on Sunday.

The public hearings were conducted at police stations on Saturday, with senior officers ranging from Special Commissioners of Police to Assistant Commissioners of Police visiting the programmes and directly interacting with citizens.

The “Thana Divas - Jansunwai” initiative was launched by the Delhi Police in June 2026 following directions from Lieu-



tenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu.

Under the initiative, public hearing sessions are held every Saturday from 10 am to 2 pm at police stations across the city. The programme is being implemented under the leadership of Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar, officials said.

YEAR OF NEXT LOK SABHA POLLS

Delhi Lakshmi Yojana RD maturity set for July 2029

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 30

The maturity date of the recurring deposit under the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana is currently set for July 31, 2029, with the Council of Ministers empowered to change it after reviewing the scheme two years after its launch. The date falls in the year of the next Lok Sabha polls, according to a document.

Applicants without an Aadhaar card can still register under the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana by providing an Aadhaar enrolment slip, where available, along with an alternative document such as a PAN card, ration card, voter identity card, passport or driving licence, it said. The Women and Child Development Department will facilitate Aadhaar enrolment for beneficiaries who have not yet obtained the identity number through its district offices. Applicants can therefore seek Aadhaar enrolment while completing registration under the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana, the document said.

“The Council of Ministers will have the power to review and change the maturity period of recurring deposits under the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana after two years of its launch,” it said.

For now, the RD has a lock-in period till July 31, 2029, which falls in the year of the next Lok Sabha polls.



CLOSER LOOK

- » Applicants without an Aadhaar card can still register under the Yojana by providing an Aadhaar enrolment slip, where available, along with an alternative document such as a PAN card, ration card, voter identity card, passport or driving licence
- » The Women and Child Development Department will facilitate Aadhaar enrolment for beneficiaries who have not yet obtained the identity number through its district offices
- » Applicants can therefore seek Aadhaar enrolment while completing registration under the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana

Under the scheme, eligible women will receive Rs 2,500 every month. Of this, Rs 1,500 will be credited to a recurring deposit account, while Rs 1,000 will be transferred through a Central Bank Digital Currency wallet linked to the beneficiary’s bank account, it mentioned.

Alternatively, beneficiaries can opt to have the entire Rs 2,500 credited every month to a recurring deposit account through the selected banking partner. The RD will have a lock-in period till July 31, 2029,

and will earn interest at the prevailing rate, it said. The Central Bank Digital Currency wallet will have spending restrictions and cannot be used to purchase items on the scheme’s negative list, including alcoholic beverages, tobacco products, narcotic drugs and psychotropic substances, lottery tickets, gambling and betting, it read.

In cases where Aadhaar authentication fails due to poor biometric quality or other reasons, beneficiaries can use iris or face authentication and Aadhaar-based

OTP. Where these methods fail, benefits may be provided against a verified physical Aadhaar letter carrying a QR code, it said.

The Delhi government formally launched the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana on August 26, with the first monthly disbursements scheduled from September 1.

Around 4000 beneficiaries had received sanction letter on August 26 under the scheme.

The scheme provides Rs 2,500 per month to eligible women and aims to support up to 17 lakh beneficiaries across the national capital.

The applicant must be a woman aged between 21 and 60 years and the eldest female member of her family. Only one woman per household can receive the benefit, while the family’s annual income must not exceed Rs 2.5 lakh. The applicant, her husband or her parents must have resided in Delhi for at least 10 years. The applicant must also be a registered voter in Delhi to qualify for the monthly financial assistance under the scheme. Income-tax payers, GST filers and government employees are excluded from the scheme. Families consuming more than 2,400 units of electricity annually or owning a four-wheeler are also not eligible for the benefit, as per the eligibility criteria of scheme.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

DDA launches digital outreach to simplify Master Plan for public

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 30

To further simplify the understanding of the Master Plan of Delhi 2047 (MPD), the DDA has launched a set of Frequently Asked Questions on its website, officials said on Sunday. Earlier, Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu had directed the DDA to initiate digital outreach measures for MPD 2047.

“As part of this initiative, DDA has made available a comprehensive set of Frequently Asked Questions on MPD-2047 on its official website, under the “What’s New” section. The FAQs provide citizens and stakeholders with simple, easily accessible information on the various provisions of the Master Plan,” the DDA said in a statement.

They cover a wide spectrum of subjects, including general provisions, development control norms, redevelopment, heritage and public spaces, land pooling policy, transit-oriented development, high-density corridors, low-density areas and in-situ slum rehabilitation. “The FAQs also address several practical aspects of MPD-2047, including land use and permissible activities, FAR and plot requirements, parking, Transferable Development Rights, eligibility and development models under Land Pooling, and eligibility, development norms and approval processes under TOD and other policies,” the DDA further said.

STEPPING OUT ON A HIGH



Aspirants leave from an examination centre after appearing in the NEET-PG 2026 examination, in New Delhi, Sunday

PTI

BRICS effect: Delhi luxury hotels sell out, rates surge

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 30

Delhi’s luxury hotel market is witnessing a sharp squeeze in room availability and a steep surge in tariffs ahead of the BRICS Summit, with several marquee properties either showing no rooms for key dates or quoting rates running into six figures a night.

A check of hotel booking platforms for September 11-13 showed no availability at Taj Mahal and Taj Palace in New Delhi, while The Oberoi, New Delhi, was

sold out for portions of the period. The Leela Palace New Delhi was not accepting bookings for the specified dates.

Rooms that were available at properties such as ITC Maurya, New Delhi and Shangri-La Eros New Delhi were commanding exceptionally high tariffs, underscoring the premium being placed on accommodation in the capital around the September 12-13 Summit.

The two-day geopolitical event is effectively compressing demand across several days, as delegates

and other visitors arrive ahead of the Summit and extend their stays, putting additional pressure on room inventory in central Delhi.

The development could leave tourists, business travellers and families with pre-planned trips to the national capital facing substantially higher accommodation costs, forcing them to either pay a premium for marquee properties, look for hotels farther from central Delhi, alter their travel dates or opt for lower-priced accommodation.

Briefs

223 kg illegal firecrackers seized in city

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has seized 223 kg of illegal firecrackers from a vehicle in outer north Delhi and arrested a 27-year-old man for allegedly possessing and transporting them without a valid licence or permit, an official said on Sunday. The action was taken on August 26 during routine patrolling in Mukundpur, the official said. According to the police, the patrol team noticed a man sitting inside a car loaded with several plastic sacks. On checking the vehicle, the sacks were found to contain Diwali-style bombs and other firecrackers.

92 challans in drunk-driving drive

NEW DELHI: Delhi Traffic Police issued 92 challans for drunken driving during a special enforcement drive conducted across the Northern Range, an official said on Sunday. The operation was conducted on Saturday on the directions of DCP Traffic, Northern Range, Sachin Kumar Singhal, aiming to reduce drunk driving and enhance road safety. “Traffic police teams adopted a strict enforcement approach against motorists found driving under the influence of alcohol during the drive,” a senior police officer said.

From 17 tonnes of waste to a cleaner Punjabi Bagh

ANAMTA FATIMA

New Delhi, August 30

At Mahatma Gandhi Camp JJ Cluster in Punjabi Bagh, a civic drive targeted sanitation, waste removal and encroachment action.

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi’s (MCD) West Zone organised the drive along Road No. 77 in Ward 92 as part of the “Delhi Ko Kude Se Azadi” campaign. The exercise brought together the MCD, Public Works Department, Delhi Jal Board and Irrigation & Flood Control Department, under the Deputy Commissioner, West Zone.

A clean-up on the ground

Around 180 Safai Karmcharis and 10 Beldars were deployed, supported by an



MRS, water sprinkler, JCBs, Tata vehicles, tippers, cycle rickshaws and wheelbarrows. The operation resulted in the removal of nearly 17 tonnes of mixed municipal solid waste from

the cluster and adjoining areas. Workers swept the main road, central verge/green belt and service lanes. Major and minor drains were cleared, while construction and demolition

waste was removed. Trees were lightly pruned and temporary encroachments were cleared.

Inter-agency action

Delhi government officials

inspected the site along with the Deputy Commissioner and Assistant Commissioner of the West Zone. The inspection reviewed sanitation arrangements, cleanliness and coordinated action by participating agencies.

The West Zone undertook coordination and follow-up with agencies to facilitate joint sanitation and encroachment-removal operations.

For a JJ cluster, the intervention highlights the challenge of sustaining cleanliness beyond one-day drives. The MCD said the campaign would continue through field-level action and inter-agency coordination to improve sanitation in JJ clusters and other areas.

City sees warm Sunday

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 30

Delhi on Sunday recorded a maximum temperature of 35.5 degrees Celsius, one notch above the seasonal average, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

The minimum temperature settled at 28 degrees Celsius, 1.5 notches above the season’s average, at the city’s representative Safdarjung weather station, the IMD said.

Among other weather stations, Palam recorded a minimum temperature of 25.4 degrees Celsius, Lodi Road 27.2 degrees, Ridge 24 degrees and Ayanagar 27 degrees.

The maximum temperature at Safdarjung

was recorded at 35.5 degrees Celsius. Lodi Road recorded a maximum of 35.2 degrees Celsius, Ridge 35 degrees, Ayanagar 34.7 degrees and Palam 34 degrees.

The India Meteorological Department has forecast a cloudy sky in the national capital on Monday, with the maximum and minimum temperature expected to remain around 36 and 26 degrees Celsius, respectively.

Relative humidity was recorded at 66 per cent at 5.30 pm.

The air quality was recorded in the ‘moderate’ category at 5 pm, with an Air Quality Index (AQI) reading of 130, according to the Sameer app.

Gurugram Metro lifts first U-girder

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, August 30

The Gurugram Metro Expansion Project reached a major construction milestone with the lifting of its first 160-tonne U-girder at Pier No. 26/27 near Cyber Park, an official said on Saturday. The U-girder was lifted around midnight using hydraulic cranes with capacities of 400 tonnes and 600 tonnes and placed at the designated location in accordance with prescribed technical and safety standards, he said.

Industries and Commerce Minister Rao Narbir Singh performed a puja to mark the commencement of the construction activity and was present during the lifting operation.

Singh said the lifting of the first U-girder marked the beginning of a new phase of construction on the ground and would give fresh momentum to the metro expansion project,

which is among the Haryana government’s key priorities. “The government’s objective is to provide modern and improved public transport facilities in Gurugram so that civic amenities expand in tandem with the city’s development,” he said. He said construction would be accelerated while ensuring strict adherence to quality and safety standards. The minister said the project was important for strengthening public transport in view of Gurugram’s rapidly expanding urban landscape and increasing traffic pressure.

Expansion of the metro network would improve connectivity between key areas of the city and provide residents with a convenient, fast and reliable mode of transport, he said.

As the project progresses, other construction activities will also be taken up expeditiously in accordance with the stipulated work plan, Singh said.

AIMAN FATIMA

New Delhi, August 30

The Delhi government has claimed significant progress in the remediation of the city’s three major landfill sites, stating that around 2.16 crore metric tonnes of waste has been processed at Okhla, Bhalswa and Ghazipur, resulting in the reclamation of 100 acres of land.

According to the Chief Minister’s Office, around 70 lakh metric tonnes of waste has been processed at the Okhla landfill, with 35 acres of land reclaimed. At Bhalswa, around 1.02 crore metric tonnes has been processed and 45 acres reclaimed, while 44 lakh metric tonnes of waste has been processed at Ghazipur, resulting in the reclamation of 20 acres.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the government had adopted a scientific and time-bound approach

THREE LANDFILLS, 100 ACRES RECLAIMED

Delhi’s landfills shed 2.16 cr MT of waste

KEY POINTS

- » According to the Chief Minister’s Office, around 70 lakh metric tonnes of waste has been processed at the Okhla landfill, with 35 acres of land reclaimed
- » At Bhalswa, around 1.02 crore metric tonnes has been processed and 45 acres reclaimed, while 44 lakh metric tonnes of waste has been processed at Ghazipur, resulting in the reclamation of 20 acres
- » Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the government had adopted a scientific and time-bound approach to address the long-pending issue of Delhi’s landfill sites
- » The Chief Minister said the initiative was aimed not only at reducing the accumulated waste but also at improving environmental conditions and the quality of life of residents living in areas surrounding the landfill sites

to address the long-pending issue of Delhi’s landfill sites.

“Priorities changed with a single vote, garbage mountains beginning to disappear in Delhi,” Gupta said.

The Chief Minister said the initiative was aimed not only at reducing the accumulated waste but also at improving environmental

conditions and the quality of life of residents living in areas surrounding the landfill sites. She said the reclamation of 100 acres of land in the Capital was a significant achievement.

“Garbage mountains had remained a major problem for the people of Delhi for years. Our government had promised to remove them and

worked towards fulfilling that commitment through a scientific roadmap, dedication and a time-bound approach,” she said.

The government has also begun utilising inert material recovered during the waste-processing exercise. At Ghazipur, the material is being used for filling low-lying areas and preparing road bases, the



CMO said. The government is simultaneously working to strengthen Delhi’s waste-processing capacity. Preparations have been completed for setting up four new Waste-to-Energy plants, which are expected to help process the waste generated in the city on a daily basis and prevent fresh accumulation at landfill sites.

“Once these plants are ready, Delhi will develop the capacity to process the waste generated every day at the same pace, ensuring that waste does not continue to accumulate and turn into new garbage mountains,” Gupta said.

The Delhi Government said its objective is to ensure scientific management of different categories of waste and process daily waste generation on a regular basis, while continuing efforts to reclaim land currently occupied by the landfill sites.

TO ATTEND SCO SUMMIT

PM Modi arrives in Kyrgyzstan

MPOST BUREAU
Bishkek, August 30

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday arrived in Kyrgyzstan, where he is scheduled to attend the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit and hold a series of bilateral meetings on the sidelines.

The prime minister was received at the airport by Kasymaliev Adylbek Aleshovich, chairman of the Cabinet of Ministers.

A traditional Kyrgyz dance performance was also held at the airport to welcome the prime minister.

“PM @narendramodi has arrived in Bishkek to participate in the 26th SCO Leadership Summit. PM was received by Mr. Adyl-



Prime Minister Narendra Modi, left, being greeted by Chairman of the Cabinet of Ministers of Kyrgyz Republic upon his arrival in Bishkek to participate in the 26th SCO Leadership Summit

bek Kasymaliev, Chairman of the Cabinet of Ministers of Kyrgyz Republic,” Ministry of

External Affairs spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal posted on X. “The SCO Summit brings together ten Member States, fifteen Partner countries and two observer countries to advance dialogue and cooperation on regional and global issues,” he added. Modi was greeted with chants of ‘Vande Mataram’ on his arrival at a hotel.

He also witnessed a vibrant yoga performance to the patriotic beats of ‘Maa Tuihe Salaam’. A Lord Shiva-themed cultural dance performance was also performed upon his arrival at the hotel. Modi is visiting Kyrgyzstan at the invitation of President Sadyr Zhaparov to participate in the 26th SCO Summit on August 31-September 1. The

10-member SCO is marking 25 years of the organisation.

It was founded in 2001 by China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan with India and Pakistan joining as full members in 2017, followed by Iran in 2023 and Belarus in 2024.

Modi is expected to hold bilateral meetings with SCO leaders, including with Kyrgyz President Zhaparov and Russian President Vladimir Putin, on the sidelines of the summit. In his departure statement on Saturday, Modi said he looked forward to advancing India’s vision for the region, anchored in “security, connectivity and opportunity, and to working with fellow members for a region free from the scourge of terrorism, separatism and

extremism, which continue to threaten peace and stability”. “I also look forward to meeting President Zhaparov and other SCO leaders,” he said. He will also attend the opening ceremony of the 6th World Nomad Games.

The prime minister said this visit will strengthen India’s strategic partnerships in Central Asia, deepen its civilisational connect with the region, and advance a shared pursuit of peace, stability and prosperity.

Modi arrived in Bishkek after a two-day trip to Uzbekistan, during which the two countries decided to elevate their ties to a comprehensive strategic partnership and set a target of USD 5 billion in annual trade by 2030.

AIR INDIA B787 ENGINE SHUTDOWN GE expanded inspections after 2023 incident, DGCA tells CIC

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, August 30

The 2023 in-flight shutdown of an engine on an Air India Boeing 787-8 aircraft prompted manufacturer GE Aerospace to expand bore-scope inspection requirements for affected engines, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has told the Central Information Commission (CIC).

The disclosure came before the CIC in an RTI case concerning action taken by the aviation regulator after the final investigation report on the uncommanded shutdown of Engine No.1 of Air India’s Boeing B787-8 aircraft VT-ANW in Mumbai on August 4, 2023.

The applicant had sought to know whether action was initiated against Air India and whether the airline was directed to conduct safety checks on its B787-8 fleet.

The DGCA told the commission that after the acceptance of the final investigation report, it was forwarded to the Directorate of Airworthiness for necessary action.

The regulator further said that GE Aerospace issued service bulletin SB 72-0543 on December 21, 2023, “expanding the bore-scope inspection requirements for the affected engines, including additional engine serial numbers”.

It said compliance with

the bulletin “was completed within the prescribed timeline” and the Directorate of Airworthiness had “treated the recommended corrective action as duly complied with”.

Queries sent to GE Aerospace and Air India remained unanswered.

The final investigation report said the aircraft, operating Air India flight AI-131 from Mumbai to London’s Heathrow Airport with 267 people on board, suffered an engine surge followed by an in-flight shutdown during the climb.

The aircraft returned to Mumbai, where it made an overweight landing on a single engine, without any injuries.

From page 1

India and Uzbekistan

finalising three sister-city and sister-state agreements. PM Modi called for a clear roadmap so the partnerships deliver results on the ground.

Mirziyoyev also shared some notable figures. He described India as a “reliable strategic partner” and said bilateral trade crossed the \$1 billion mark last year for the first time. Joint ventures have also increased sevenfold compared to a few years ago. Travel has become easier as well. There are now 14 direct flights a week connecting the two countries, according to Mirziyoyev. India and Uzbekistan already cooperate in trade, investment, education, pharmaceuticals, IT and culture. Nuclear energy and city planning are the latest additions to that list. For India, Uzbekistan is emerging as an increasingly important partner in Central Asia. The two sides inked 11 agreements to boost engagement in several key sectors, including mining and tourism. The Modi-Mirziyoyev talks focused on expanding cooperation in areas of trade, investment, infrastructure, critical minerals, mining, defence and security, agriculture, pharmaceuticals, health, information technology, digital public infrastructure, including UPI and education.

Both leaders announced elevating the India-Uzbekistan strategic ties to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, reflecting the growing depth and expanding scope of cooperation.

Modi and Mirziyoyev witnessed the exchange of agreements covering a wide range of areas such as mining, culture, education, tourism, ayurveda, among others. “Uzbekistan is at the heart of Central Asia and is at the heart of India’s engagement in the region,” Modi said.

The prime minister added: “A stronger India-Uzbekistan partnership will be a powerful force for peace, progress and prosperity in Central Asia.”

Delving into the ambitious agenda of future cooperation between the two sides, Modi said India and Uzbekistan will encourage their defence industries to look at co-development and co-production of military hardware. On trade and investment, he said issues relating to market access, banking, payment systems and connectivity will be addressed in a structured way. “The close defence and security cooperation between our two countries reflects our deep mutual trust. In the future, we will promote direct linkages, co-production, and co-development between our defence industries,” Modi said.

“We believe that terrorism, extremism, and separatism pose serious challenges to the entire region.” “Maintaining a policy of zero tolerance against these threats has been, and will continue to be, our shared resolve,” he added. A Letter of Intent for the restoration and conservation of the Buddhist sites of Fayaz

Tepa and Kara Tepa in Uzbekistan was also agreed upon.

These ancient Buddhist monasteries in southern Uzbekistan highlight how Buddhism spread along the Silk Road and flourished in Central Asia.

The two sides announced that a commercial pact was firming up between NPCI International Payments Ltd (NPCI) and Uzbekistan’s National Interbank Processing Centre JSC to enable UPI apps of India to scan national QR - UZQR for making merchant payments in the Central Asian nation. Modi landed in Tashkent on Saturday on a two-day visit to bolster ties with Uzbekistan in a range of areas.

A joint statement said the prime minister and the Uzbek president agreed to explore cooperation in the fields of geology, mining, nuclear energy, industrial cooperation, and critical and strategic minerals, including projects for the processing of mineral resources, production of value-added products and recycling initiatives. “They also expressed interest in encouraging Indian companies to participate in the development of prospective mineral deposits in Uzbekistan and Uzbek enterprises for joint collaboration in India. The leaders expressed interest in extended cooperation in peaceful uses of nuclear energy,” it said. The statement said Modi and Mirziyoyev agreed to expand cooperation in critical minerals through joint projects in geological exploration, mining, mineral processing, and the development of integrated value chains. The Uzbek president said his country is determined to boost ties with India in diverse sectors. “We are aiming to advance cooperation in sectors such as energy, culture, critical minerals, pharmaceuticals, jewellery, and agriculture.”

“We will prepare roadmaps for each of these sectors; specific teams from India will visit here, and our teams will travel to India, enabling us to clearly define our objectives in these fields,” he said. The joint statement said the two leaders welcomed the close alignment of their positions and the growing importance of Central Asia.

Amid a complex geopolitical situation, they stressed the need for a free, open and rules-based international order. Building on their multilateral cooperation, it said.

Modi conferred

of his leadership and contribution to bilateral ties.

Modi is in Uzbekistan on a two-day visit to bolster ties in a range of areas including trade, clean energy and connectivity.

The prime minister was conferred with the honour by Uzbek President Shavkat Mirziyoyev.

“Honoured to receive the Oliy Darajali Do’sstlik Order. I dedicate this to the enduring bond between India and Uzbekistan,” Modi said in a social media post.

The Ministry of External Affairs said on X that the prime minister was conferred the honour for his “contribution in strengthening the friendship between the two countries”.

“PM dedicated the accolade

to the 1.4 billion people of India and highlighted that it is a symbol of the enduring friendship between the two civilisations,” it said. In his remarks, Modi said receiving the award was a matter of great pride for him.

He said the people of India are very familiar with the word used for the award – ‘Dostlik’.

“There is hardly a family in India where the word ‘Dostlik’ is not spoken a hundred times a day. Today, you have truly brought out the essence of it. ‘Dostlik’ means friendship. The word itself beautifully expresses the sentiment at the heart of the relationship between India and Uzbekistan,” he said.

In July, Indonesia conferred upon Modi its highest civilian award, the ‘Bintang Adipurna of the Republic of Indonesia’, recognising his contribution to strengthening bilateral ties between the two countries.

AGENCIES

Nepal flood

away, while several hydropower projects were damaged.

The disaster also affected neighbouring China, where 16 people were reported dead and 546 missing on the Chinese side. Chinese media reports said the missing included 261 foreigners from 23 countries, among them 49 Indians.

India has been among the countries most closely involved in the rescue and relief response. The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) in New Delhi said on Saturday that more than 275 Indians and 128 persons of Indian origin remained missing or non-contactable in Nepal. On Sunday, the ministry’s X handle published a list of 149 Indians who had been rescued.

The Indian response has also expanded beyond evacuation and relief distribution. An 18-member team of forensic experts from India specialising in DNA analysis has arrived in Nepal to help authorities identify victims whose remains have been difficult to recognise.

Nepal’s Foreign Secretary Amrit Bahadur Rai said on Sunday that the mortal remains of victims who could not be identified, including those that were unrecognisable, amputated or decomposed after prolonged exposure to water, had been buried according to “standard and accepted protocols”.

“Medical teams have taken DNA samples from every victim prior to the burial so that families can match records later. They will be allowed to exhumate for necessary rituals,” Rai said.

The forensic team is working with Nepali authorities as the identification process continues.

Hospitals across Nepal have seen large crowds of relatives searching for missing family members. Photographs of missing people and recovered victims have been displayed outside hospitals, with families examining them in the hope of finding information. But identifying the dead has proved difficult. Police said only 17 of the bodies recovered so far have been identified. “Only 17 bodies have been identified so far as most of the bodies are either in a dilapidated state or amputated,”

said Rajendra Prasad Dhamala, spokesperson for the Bagmati Province Police Office.

Dhamala said 96 bodies had been buried after the required legal procedures were completed. DNA samples were collected before burial and preserved at designated locations, allowing families to seek identification later. Identified bodies are being handed over to relatives after verification.

India is also directly supporting search operations at damaged hydropower facilities. An 11-member Indian team has joined the Nepali Army in efforts to rescue workers believed to be trapped inside the Upper Trishuli-3A hydropower project tunnel in flood-hit Nuwakot.

Nepali Army engineers intensified operations on Sunday, using heavy equipment and blasting to widen an opening into the buried tunnel.

A total of 537 workers and employees remain unaccounted for at nine hydropower projects in Rasuwa and Nuwakot districts. The Upper Trishuli-3A tunnel is among the sites where rescue operations are under way. “The tunnel rescue team from India worked with the Nepali Army’s team to conduct search & rescue operations at hydropower tunnel sites in Chilime and Langtang area today. The team will continue to conduct search and rescue operations in close coordination with the Nepali Army,” the Indian embassy in Nepal said in a social media post on Sunday.

India has also sent large quantities of relief supplies. The Indian embassy said 68.5 tonnes of relief material had been provided to Nepal, along with technical teams, forensic specialists and equipment for search and rescue operations.

“The fourth flight, carrying 11 tons of relief materials, has arrived in Nepal, and those relief materials have been handed over,” the Indian mission said. The shipment included equipment for the tunnel rescue team, forensic equipment for DNA analysis, blankets, sleeping bags, tarpaulins, plastic sheets and hygiene kits. In addition, 37 trucks and 35 SUVs loaded with food supplies, along with eight helicopters carrying food and non-food relief material, have been sent to affected areas. The NDRRMA issued another warning on Sunday after water levels in the Bhotekoshi River rose again. “The water level in the flooded Bhotekoshi River has risen to some extent; all concerned are urged to take precautionary measures,” the authority said. It added that further information would be provided after receiving additional updates on the situation.

Nepal’s meteorology department had already warned on Saturday of fresh rainfall and thunderstorms in areas affected by the flash floods. Such weather could make search, rescue and relief operations more difficult.

Fears of another major flood had also emerged after a lake formed on the Chinese side following the August 26 glacier-related collapse. Chinese media reports said the size of the barrier lake began shrinking on Saturday, reducing the immediate threat. However, fresh reports on Sunday said a landslide near the natural dam had created another “dam lake”, leading rescue personnel to evacuate the area. The floods have severely disrupted Nepal’s transport network. Nineteen motorable bridges and several highways and arterial roads were washed away on August 26.

Transport services have also been suspended along the Prithvi Highway, a major route connecting Kathmandu with Pokhara and western Nepal. A section of the highway at Krishnabhir was washed away by the Trishuli River. Officials said restoration would take time and advised travellers to use alternative routes.

The power sector has suffered major losses as well. According to the Independent Power Producers’ Association Nepal, eight operational hydropower projects with a combined capacity of 354 MW were damaged. Five additional projects under construction in Nuwakot and Rasuwa districts were also affected. The Nepalese government has deployed more than 20,000 security personnel for search and rescue operations. Helicopters have been making repeated sorties to evacuate stranded residents and tourists and to deliver essential supplies.

Nearly 9,500 people had been rescued by Sunday evening, including local residents and tourists from India, the United States, China, Russia, the United Kingdom, Spain, Belgium, Germany, Italy, Malta, Turkey, Switzerland and Portugal. The preliminary data released by Nepal’s education ministry also showed that those missing include 238 students and 18 teachers from schools in three flood-affected districts. As search operations continue, survivors face the difficult task of rebuilding homes and livelihoods while many families remain separated from loved ones. Authorities are simultaneously working to recover and identify the dead, restore transport links and reach workers still believed to be trapped at damaged hydropower sites.

For India, the response has involved relief supplies, specialist rescue personnel, forensic support and technical assistance, with teams working alongside Nepalese authorities as the Himalayan nation continues to deal with the aftermath of one of its most destructive recent flood disasters.

New rules mandate

of NavIC, India’s indigenous satellite navigation system, and other approved Indian timing sources for secure time dissemination. The initiative is part of the government’s “One Nation, One Time” programme. In July 2026, the ministry commissioned a White Rabbit Technology-based IST Dissemination Demonstration Network at the Regional Reference Standard Laboratory (RRSL) in Bengaluru.

A separate demonstration involving the ministry, CSIR-National Physical Laboratory,

Isro, Sebi, the National Stock Exchange (NSE) and BSNL showed secure transmission of IST between RRSL Bengaluru and NSE Chennai.

The ministry said the 180-day transition period will allow stakeholders to assess existing systems, undertake technical upgrades and prepare for implementation.

SC to hear today plea

below Rs 2,000 without disclosure of the donor’s identity reduces transparency in political funding.

According to the petitioner, voters have a right to know who funds political parties and the reasons behind such funding. The plea argues that withholding this information can prevent voters from making a “rational, intelligent and fully informed decision” while exercising their franchise.

The petitioner has asked the court to declare Clause (d) of Section 13A unconstitutional. It has also sought directions to the Election Commission to make disclosure of the donor’s name and other particulars mandatory for political parties. The plea further seeks a rule barring parties from accepting any cash donations.

Section 13A provides exemptions from the computation of total income for political parties in relation to income from interest on securities, house property, other sources and voluntary contributions, subject to prescribed conditions.

The plea has also sought greater scrutiny of political parties’ contribution reports. It wants the Election Commission to examine Form 24A reports filed by all recognised political parties and require parties to deposit contributions for which the donor’s address or Permanent Account Number, or PAN, has not been provided.

It further asks the poll panel to issue notices under the Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order, 1968, to parties that fail to submit complete Form 24A reports within the prescribed period. The notices, it said, should seek an explanation as to why the party’s reserved election symbol should not be suspended or withdrawn.

The petitioner has also sought directions for political parties to maintain their accounts in a prescribed format and have them audited by independent auditors appointed by the Election Commission.

Another request concerns the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT). The plea wants the tax authority to scrutinise the income tax returns and audit reports submitted by political parties under Sections 142 and 143 of the Income Tax Act for the previous five years.

It has also sought appropriate action, including tax, penalty and prosecution, against parties that fail to meet the requirements of Section 13A read with Section 29C of the Representation of the People Act, 1951. Section 29C deals with the declaration of donations received by political parties.

The petition has cited the Supreme Court’s 2024 judgment that struck down the electoral bonds scheme. The scheme, notified by the government on January 2, 2018, had been presented as an alternative to cash donations to political parties and as a measure aimed at improving transparency in political funding.

The petitioner has argued that the principles laid down by the Supreme Court in that judgment also warrant greater disclosure of political contributions received in cash.

India emerges

crude since 2022. Russian oil has become a major source of feedstock for Indian refiners, raising the possibility that some of the petrol now being shipped back to Russia was produced from Russian crude.

India imported more than 2.6 million barrels per day of Russian crude in June and July, up from around 1 million bpd in February. Russian crude accounted for more than half of India’s total crude imports during those two months, as conflict in the Gulf tightened supplies from other sources.

Russia’s gasoline shortage has been aggravated by attacks on its energy infrastructure, which have at times cut domestic production by as much as 70 per cent. The disruption has created a fuel supply gap even as Moscow continues to restrict fuel sales and has sought additional imports.

Besides India, Turkey and Morocco supplied gasoline to Russia in August. Russia extended its complete gasoline export ban for producers and non-producers through the end of January 2027. Its ban on diesel exports has been extended through September 1, 2026.

Logistics around the gasoline trade have also drawn attention. Vortexa said about 55 per cent, or roughly 260,000 tonnes, of Russia’s gasoline imports in August arrived on sanctioned vessels. “All India-origin gasoline cargoes Russia imported in August were carried on sanctioned fleets and involved dark ship-to-ship (STS) transfers in the Mediterranean,” the firm said.

Overall, about 40 per cent of Russia’s August gasoline imports were transferred between ships, with most such operations conducted in the dark. Vessels involved typically switched off their automatic identification system (AIS) signals.

Russia’s diesel exports remain under pressure. Vortexa recorded seaborne diesel and gasoil exports of about 150,000 bpd through August 25, unchanged from July but 610,000 bpd below a year earlier and 81 per cent below the five-year seasonal average.

Vortexa said 32 attacks targeted Russian refineries in July and August, averaging about one every other day. It expects Russia to continue importing some gasoline in the near term, partly because the country has historically produced less gasoline relative to diesel.

Briefs

Goa Assembly session from today

PANAJI: The three-day monsoon session of the Goa Assembly will begin on Monday, with a discussion likely on the proposed anti-conversion legislation, which has drawn criticism from Opposition parties.

The House will take up 883 questions during the session, submitted by members of both the ruling and Opposition parties, Joint Secretary (Legislature Department) told media.

Divya Mittal quits IAS after 13 yrs

IAS OFFICER Divya Mittal has resigned from the civil services after nearly 13 years, saying she was stepping away from the post voluntarily after a journey that taught her more from ordinary people than she could have imagined.

Mittal shared an emotional message on social media announcing her decision and reflecting on her journey from a modest background to the Indian Administrative Service and her experiences while serving in different parts of UP.

Rajnath calls for talent pipeline

LUCKNOW: Defence minister Rajnath Singh on Sunday stressed the need to develop a skilled, future-ready talent pipeline alongside India's expanding defence manufacturing ecosystem.

Speaking at the PM-SETU Industry Conclave in Lucknow, Singh said an "aatmanirbhar defence industry" must be supported by an "aatmanirbhar talent pipeline".

IAS officer held in exam irregularities

BENGALURU: CID officials arrested IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar over alleged irregularities in the KPSC recruitment examination for veterinary officers, official sources said on Sunday.

He was subsequently produced before a First Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate at the judge's residence and was remanded to judicial custody. He was later taken to Parappana Agrahara prison, they added.

'No justice if some voices unheard'

CHANDIGARH: Rajya Sabha MP Ashok Kumar Mittal has called for a serious national discussion to establish a "national commission for men", bringing together researchers, legal experts, counselors, social workers and policymakers to systematically study issues affecting men. He was speaking at an event here, after a report documenting cases of male intimate partner murders and suicides among men in India was unveiled, a press release said.

MONTHLY RADIO ADDRESS 'MANN KI BAAT'

Make India drug-free: PM Modi appeals to citizens

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, August 30

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday appealed to citizens to unite against drug abuse and build a stronger future for the youth, noting that addiction engulfs not just an individual but impacts the entire society.

In his monthly radio address 'Mann Ki Baat', he noted that the 'Drug-Free Youth for a Developed India' campaign is rapidly gaining momentum across the country and stressed that its objective is clear: 'Drug-free youth, drug-free India'.

The Prime Minister said he was happy that this campaign has not remained merely a formality as many people, especially the youth, are becoming a part of it in large numbers.

"After all, this is our collective resolve for the health, happiness, and bright future of India's youth. Let us all play our part in this noble mission to keep India's youth away from drugs and free from addiction," he said.

Modi said drug addiction does not just engulf a single individual as the entire family and society have to bear the consequences.

"I would like to commend those who raise awareness against drugs and step forward to help individuals struggling with



Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra and others listen to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's 'Mann Ki Baat' radio programme, in New Delhi, Sunday

CLOSER LOOK

- » The PM said he was happy that this campaign has not remained merely a formality as many people are becoming a part of it in large numbers
- » Modi said drug addiction does not just engulf a single individual as the entire family and society have to bear the consequences

addiction," he said.

Drug-Free India through the 'Nasha Mukht Bharat Abhiyaan' (NMBA) is a flagship initiative of the government. The campaign seeks to prevent substance abuse through awareness generation, community participation, treatment, rehabilitation, aftercare and social reintegration.

The prime minister also highlighted the PM SVANidhi Yojana welfare scheme for street vendors, noting that lakhs of women are gaining strength from it.

Lakhs of women across the streets of cities and towns are engaged in selling vegetables or fruits, running tea stalls, while some are selling flowers, earthen lamps, and 'pooja' material, he noted.

"Often, a mere lack of capital prevents their businesses from growing further. But now, lakhs of such mothers and sisters are gaining new strength through the 'PM SVANidhi Yojana'," he said.

Modi said this aspect of 'women empowerment' is

Jarange sets Sept 12 deadline over Mumbai protests

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Jalna/Nagpur, August 30

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Sunday reached out to fast-ing Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange, who has warned of marching to Mumbai if the government fails to act on his demand for Kunbi (OBC) caste certificates for all eligible Marathas by September 12.

Fadnavis said the government is open to discuss legally viable demands that are constitutionally valid, and not violative of the Supreme Court's orders.

On the second day of the indefinite hunger strike in Antarwali Sarati village in Jalna district, Jarange targeted Deputy CM Eknath Shinde, who belongs to the Maratha community, rebel Shiv Sena MP Sanjay Jadhav, and state minister Sanjay Shirsat over a farmer event being held in Parbhani city in the Marathwada region.

not discussed as much as it should be since women account for approximately 46 percent of the beneficiaries of the 'PM SVANidhi Yojana'.

"This means that around 35 lakh women across the country are expanding their businesses by connecting with this scheme," he asserted.

Referring to two women -- one from Ghaziabad and the other from Bengaluru --who have benefited from the 'PM SVANidhi Yojana', the prime minister said when a woman's business grows, the future of her entire family advances along with it. "Children receive better education, household needs are met, and the woman's self-confidence is strengthened. This is, indeed, a living example of 'women's empowerment'," he said.

KHARGE 'PURIFICATION' ROW PM Modi must get FIR filed against culprits under SC/ST Act: Priyanka

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, August 30

Upping the ante against the BJP, Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra on Sunday said that if Prime Minister Narendra Modi truly respects the Constitution, then he should ensure that an FIR is filed against those who committed the "crime" of carrying out 'shuddhikaran' at the venue where party chief Mallikarjun Kharge addressed a rally in Uttarakhand's Haldwani.

Priyanka Gandhi asserted that Modi must ensure that action is taken under the SC/ST Act against those who carried out the "shuddhikaran (purification)" ceremony earlier this month.

"Congress President Shri Mallikarjun Kharge ji addressed a rally in Haldwani, after which people from BJP-RSS 'purified' his stage. This 'purification'

Punjab: AAP leader Gurpreet Gopi shot dead in Ferozepur

Gopi's father Balkar Singh was a former Cong leader

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Ferozepur, August 30

AAP leader Gurpreet Singh alias Gopi was shot dead by four armed assailants in this district, with police on Sunday saying the killing was linked to an election-related dispute.

The four car-borne assailants got down from their vehicle in the main bazaar of Mamdot here on Saturday evening and opened fire at 45-year-old Singh and Harpreet alias Happy (22) who were on a motorcycle.

Earlier reports had suggested that the victims were in a car.

According to sources, the newly appointed president of Mamdot Nagar Panchayat Vicky Maini from the AAP was following Singh in a separate car. He also came under attack but escaped unhurt, the sources said.



THE SSP SAID THE KILLING WAS AN OUTCOME OF PERSONAL ENMITY RELATED TO RECENT MUNICIPAL COUNCIL ELECTIONS

The injured were rushed to the Civil Hospital where the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) leader was declared brought dead, while Harpreet was referred to a private hospital in Ludhiana.

Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP) Bhupinder Singh said police have identified the accused and police teams have been dispatched to nab them.

The SSP said the killing was an outcome of personal enmity related to the recent municipal council elections.

Singh's father Balkar Singh was a former Congress leader, while his sister-in-law had also been elected as member of the nagar panchayat recently.

'RLD will expand beyond western UP'

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

Lucknow, August 30

Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) president and Union minister Jayant Chaudhary on Sunday hit out at Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, accusing some political leaders of viewing every dispute through a political lens and trying to derive political mileage from it.

Addressing a RLD function at the Indira Gandhi Pratishthan in Lucknow, Chaudhary invoked his

grandfather and former Prime Minister Chaudhary Charan Singh, saying he had taught his followers to respect people from all sections of society and opposed caste-based politics.

"Chaudhary Charan Singh taught us to respect everyone. He did not practise caste politics. He wanted every section of society to progress," Chaudhary said.

Without naming Akhilesh directly, he said the real issue was not caste

but "arrogance, corruption, theft and fraud". He said Chaudhary Charan Singh had taught the RLD a different "ABCD", based on respect and social responsibility.

Chaudhary said several political parties had been formed in the name of Chaudhary Charan Singh and had invoked his name during elections.

While he did not object to this, he said putting up his photograph was easier than following his ideals.

Rahul invoking Kharge's Dalit identity for political gains: BJP leaders

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Patna, August 30

Senior BJP leaders on Sunday accused Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi of using the "untouchability plank to ruin India" and "invoking the Dalit identity of Congress president" Mallikarjun Kharge for political gains.

This came a day after Gandhi demanded that Prime Minister Narendra Modi order the registration of an FIR against those who carried out 'shuddhikaran' (purification) at the venue where party chief Mallikarjun Kharge addressed a rally in Uttarakhand's Haldwani, saying it was a crime according to the Constitution.

He alleged the purification was carried out by BJP and RSS workers on August 10, two days after Kharge's rally in the Uttarakhand city, and said the Congress president raised the issue in Parliament on August 13.

Taking a swipe at Gandhi, Union Minister Giriraj Singh said, "He has developed a sense of untouchability towards India, and he is hell-bent on ruining the country. Untouchability is deeply embedded within the Congress."

About the alleged 'purification' event in Haldwani following Kharge's speech, Singh told PTI Videos that "a programme was conducted at the venue by a group of children belonging to the Scheduled Castes community".

Taking a dig at Rahul Gandhi, the Union minister said, "The Congress' problem is that every day it tries to dress up a jackal in a lion's skin. But a jackal ultimately remains a jackal."

NEW JAMMU & KASHMIR TERROR TACTIC

Pornography Apps, Tor network used for secret messaging

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Srinagar, August 30

After exposing the misuse of online gaming platforms by terror groups, security agencies have uncovered a new operational tactic adopted by terrorists and their handlers who are now using pornography websites and niche encrypted applications to communicate secretly, officials said on Sunday.

The covert channels are being used by terror outfits and Pakistan's intelligence agency, ISI, to convey instructions to recruits in Jammu and Kashmir while evading surveillance on

conventional social media platforms.

Officials said these pornography platforms feature real-time chat tools, operating under the guise of helping users find dates nearby, which handlers exploit to broadcast messages and coordinate activities.

Security agencies have placed a wide array of specialised digital tools under scrutiny. Terror handlers are relying on Tor-based messaging applications like Coatex and Conion to route data through encrypted nodes and obscure user identities.

Access to the APK for Conion reportedly faces

KEY POINTS

- » The covert channels are being used by terror outfits and Pakistan's intelligence agency, ISI, to convey instructions to recruits in J&K
- » Officials said these pornography platforms feature real-time chat tools, operating under the guise of helping users find dates nearby

restrictions within India. An APK file (Android Package Kit) is the file format used by the Android operating system to distribute and install mobile apps.

Additionally, they are using privacy-focused platforms such as a France-based app that allows

end-to-end encrypted messaging without requiring a SIM card or phone number, making user attribution difficult.

Agencies are also monitoring Vietnam-based apps alongside anonymous platforms like Moonchat, which includes PGP-encrypted

versions with suspected Chinese origins that bypass traditional registration. This app has many versions used for finding singles in your vicinity.

Though several of these porn applications are banned in India, they are downloaded illegally using Virtual Private Network (VPN). A VPN creates a secure and encrypted connection over the internet by masking Internet Protocol addresses and encrypting online traffic, making it more difficult to track online activity and access data. Security experts feel that many platforms using the Tor network present

unique tracking challenges by bouncing encrypted traffic through multiple volunteer-run relay nodes globally to hide both the origin and destination of the data. While Tor is maintained by the US-based non-profit, The Tor Project, for legitimate privacy and anti-censorship efforts, its anonymity features are increasingly being exploited by clandestine networks including terror groups.

The officials said that security agencies continue to adapt their cyber-surveillance frameworks to map and intercept these off-grid communication channels.

RE-TEST ANNOUNCED FOR CANDIDATES AT 2 JAIPUR CENTRES

Over 2.63L appear in NEET-PG

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 30

The NEET-PG 2026 was successfully conducted for more than 2.63 lakh candidates across the country on Sunday, but the examination could not be completed at two centres in Rajasthan’s Jaipur due to an internal power failure, officials said.

The National Board of Examinations in Medical Sciences (NBEMS) has scheduled a re-examination for the affected candidates in Jaipur at 3 pm on September 5, according to a notice issued by it.

The NBEMS has also called an immediate meeting to decide the course of action against the technological partner and agency responsible for ensuring adequate infrastructure at the examination centres, officials said.

At the two iON Digital Zone centres in Sitapura, Jaipur, the examination could not be completed for 2,445 candidates due to internal power-supply issues attributable to TCS Ltd, the technological partner and the examination-conducting agency, the health ministry said.

The affected centres are iON Digital Zone iDZ Sitapura (TC Nos. 41682 and 41683). Further details, including the venue for the re-examination and revised admit cards, will be shared separately, the board said.

The NEET-PG was scheduled for 2,73,096 candidates at 1,111 examination centres across 339 cities, covering all 36 states and



Aspirants leave from an examination centre after appearing in the NEET-PG 2026 examination, in Ranchi, Sunday

KEY POINTS

- » The affected centres are iON Digital Zone iDZ Sitapura (TC Nos. 41682 and 41683)
- » The NEET-PG was scheduled for 2,73,096 candidates at 1,111 examination centres across 339 cities, covering all 36 states and Union territories, the ministry said

Union territories, the ministry said.

A total of 2,65,980 candidates appeared in the NEET-PG, with the examination successfully completed for approximately 2,63,535 candidates, the ministry said.

The nationwide examination was supported by extensive real-time monitoring and stringent security measures, it added.

A total of 2,527 faculty members were appointed as independent appraisers

to oversee the conduct of the examination. In addition, more than 700 senior faculty members, including deans, directors, medical superintendents and senior professors, were deployed as Flying Squad members.

To strengthen coordination and monitoring, 16 NBEMS regional command centres were made operational across the country, the ministry said.

The examination centres were also placed under live CCTV surveillance,

which was continuously monitored from the NBEMS Command Centre at its headquarters in Delhi’s Dwarka. A dedicated team of 190 personnel from the NBEMS and TCS was deployed for real-time surveillance and monitoring, the ministry said.

At the dedicated Command Centre at the NBEMS headquarters, officials from the board, the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, BEL, ECIL and TCS maintained close and continuous oversight of the examination process throughout the day, it said.

As part of the measures to further strengthen examination security and prevent impersonation, Aadhaar-based authentication of candidates was successfully undertaken at the examination centres.

Serving others is highest duty, says Khattar

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, August 30

Union minister Manohar Lal Khattar said that serving others is the highest duty and everyone should, according to their means, extend support to the needy and deserving, both within their families and in society.

The Union minister was addressing a programme organised by Sarv Jan Sukhay Trust, Kaithal, at RKSD College on Sunday to mark the laying of the foundation stone of ‘Anandam Vridhi Seva Aangan’, an old-age home to be constructed at village Dayora for the welfare and care of senior citizens.

Khattar unveiled the foundation plaque in the presence of Haryana Vidhan Sabha Deputy Speaker, Krishan Lal Middha, Social Justice and Empowerment minister, Krishan Kumar Bedi, MP, Naveen Jindal and other dignitaries.

ON SUPREME COURT BENCH

Justice Bhuyan flags 76-year absence of ‘distinguished jurists’

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 30

Supreme Court judge Ujjal Bhuyan on Sunday batted in favour of appointing ‘distinguished jurists’ as judges of the top court, stating that such an inclusion would diversify the bench with talent and let scholars of repute contribute to the decision-making process.

Justice Bhuyan said it was regrettable that despite Article 124 (3)(c) of the Constitution enabling such an appointment, no person other than high court judges or practising lawyers has reached the Supreme Court in the last 76 years.

He remarked that either the Centre and Collegium found that there was “not enough depth” in the Indian academia to be “seriously considered” for judgeship, or



Justice Ujjal Bhuyan

both authorities have not “seriously explored this provision thus far”.

Justice Bhuyan called the assertion that legal scholars lack practical experience a “very shallow objection”, adding that distinguished academics are appointed as constitutional courts’ judges in several countries, including the United States of America, Great Britain, Canada and Kenya.

Justice Bhuyan was speaking at the 13th convocation ceremony for the postgraduate students of

National Law University, Delhi.

“No jurist has been appointed so far to the Supreme Court, though the Constitution has completed more than 76 years. It is regrettable that this provision has remained one of our Constitution’s unused mandates,” Justice Bhuyan said.

“No legal academic has yet been appointed as the judge of the Supreme Court despite there being some brilliant minds who could have made a substantial contribution had they become part of the bench,” he added.

Justice Bhuyan also said that students expressing a different point of view or asking questions cannot be threatened with punitive action, as such an approach is unconstitutional and a misuse of power.

HP: 3 new judges inducted in High Court bench

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Shimla, August 30

Chirag Bhanu Singh, a senior district and sessions judge, today took oath as a Judge of the High Court of Himachal Pradesh, while Bhupesh Sharma and Yogesh Jaswal took oath as Additional Judges of the High Court for a term of two years.

The oath of office was administered by the Governor of Himachal Pradesh Kavinder Gupta at a ceremony held at Lok Bhavan,



Shimla, in the presence of the Chief Justice of the High Court of Himachal Pradesh Justice Gurmeet Singh Sandhawalia

The strength of the high court judges has risen to 15 including Chief Justice.

Those attended the ceremony included Speaker of the Himachal Pradesh Legislative Assembly Kuldeep Singh Pathania, Health and Family Welfare Minister Col (rtd) Dhani Ram Shandil and Judges of the High Court- Justice Vivek Singh Thakur, justice Bipin Chander Negi, Justice Jyotsna Rewal Dua, Justice Sushil Kukreja, Justice Virender Singh, Justice Ranjan Sharma, Justice Bipin Chander Negi, Justice Rakesh Kainthla and Justice

Jiya Lal Bhardwaj.

Former Chief Justice of the High Court of Jharkhand Justice Tarlok Singh Chauhan, former Acting Chief Justice of the High Court of Himachal Pradesh Justice Sabina, Registrar General, Chief Secretary, Registrars, Judicial Officers of the State, President, Bar Association of Himachal Pradesh, other members of the High Court Bar Association and other dignitaries of the State were also present on the occasion.

Briefs

Raj: Four drown in pond

JAIPUR: A 21-year-old man, his two sisters, and a cousin drowned in a pond in Dholpur district early Sunday morning police said.

The four went to the pond early in the morning. Ravi entered the water for a bath and began drowning.

Seeing him struggle, his three sisters jumped into the water to rescue him, but they drowned.

Manipur: One militant killed

IMPHAL: At least one militant was killed and six others were injured in a gunfight between two factions of an armed group in Manipur’s Noney district, officials said on Sunday..

Police said the deceased has been identified as Jangailing Gonmei (37).

BJP gains strength in Lehragaga

CHANDIGARH: The Bharatiya Janata Party received a significant boost in the Lehragaga area in Punjab as people from various sections joined the party, expressing confidence in the leadership of Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini and the policies of the BJP.

More than three dozen people from Patiala, Mansa, Sangrur, Patran and Lehragaga joined the BJP.

Akhilesh-Rahul ties headed for split: Rajbhar

Says SP has no chance in 2027

BISWAJEET BANERJEE
Ambedkar Nagar, August 30

Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP) chief and Uttar Pradesh minister Om Prakash Rajbhar on Sunday claimed that the political ties between Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi were headed for a break.

Speaking in Ambedkar Nagar, Rajbhar said the differences and public statements emerging between the two leaders indicated that Rahul Gandhi was preparing to distance himself from the Samajwadi Party.

Rajbhar claimed that Rahul Gandhi had realised that the Samajwadi Party had little chance of forming the government in Uttar Pradesh in 2027.

He said the Congress leader could eventually move away from the SP to avoid the political controversies and allegations surrounding the party from affecting the Congress.

Taking a dig at Akhilesh Yadav’s claim that the SP would form the government in Uttar Pradesh in 2027, Rajbhar said the former chief minister’s dream of returning to power had already ended. He sarcastically suggested that Yadav should prepare for his “next birth” instead of preparing to form the government.

Rajbhar also attacked Akhilesh Yadav over the SP’s latest interpretation of PDA. Referring to the terms patience, discipline and action, he said Yadav should first teach these principles to his own party workers.

He also targeted the previous SP government over law and order, alleging that incidents of theft, snatching, robbery, dacoity and murder had taken place during its tenure without effective action against criminals.

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NFR extends 3 pairs of special trains



OUR CORRESPONDENT
Maligaon, August 30

Northeast Frontier Railway (NFR) has extended the services of three pairs of Festival Special trains to provide additional travel options and facilitate the smooth movement of passengers during the upcoming festive season.

These services have been extended to meet the expected passenger rush during the extra rush and festive seasons. The trains will operate as per their existing service schedule, timings, composition and stoppages. The operation and extension of these special train services will significantly benefit passengers by providing additional travel options and easing congestion on busy routes.

AFTER NEPAL TRAGEDY

Himachal steps up monitoring of 67 glacier lakes

ASHWANI SHARMA
Shimla, August 30

In the middle of the monsoon season, when the threat of natural disasters looms large over the state, Himachal Pradesh has stepped up its monitoring of 67 vulnerable glacier lakes, most of which are located in the high-altitude mountains.

The heightened surveillance comes in the wake of an unprecedented spate of flash floods and glacier-related disasters in Nepal, which left large parts of the country devastated and once again underscored the growing risks posed by glacial lakes and rapidly changing weather patterns in the Himalayan region.



Residential buildings covered in thick mud in the aftermath of flash floods, in Nuwakot district, Sunday

cial lakes and rapidly changing weather patterns in the Himalayan region.

With Himachal Pradesh also home to numerous glacial lakes and vulnerable mountain settlements,

authorities are keeping a close watch on water levels, weather conditions and other early warning indicators to detect any signs of a potential glacial lake outburst flood (GLOF) or other disaster.

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Officials say the exercise is aimed at strengthening preparedness and ensuring that timely alerts can be issued to communities
- » Rana said the state was monitoring these lakes through satellite-based observations and other available data. The number is certainly a matter of concern

The monitoring assumes particular significance during the monsoon, when intense rainfall, cloudbursts and sudden changes in temperature can destabilise high-altitude terrain and increase the risk of flash floods and landslides.

Officials say the exercise is aimed at strengthening preparedness and ensuring that timely alerts can be issued to communities living downstream of vulnerable lakes and river valleys, where even a sudden breach can trigger devastating floods.

Says Puspinder Rana, Special secretary, state Disaster Management Authority “Himachal Pradesh has identified 67 vulnerable glacial lakes which pose threat of disasters. The government is preparing to set-up an early warning systems for four of the most vulnerable lakes in Kinnaur and Lahaul-Spiti, both tribal district bordering Chinese occupied Tibet region”

Rana said the state was monitoring these lakes through satellite-based observations and other available data. The number is certainly a matter of concern.

Nomadic communities occupy distinguished place: CM Saini

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, August 30

Nomadic communities have a long, glorious and inspiring history. Even in the most challenging circumstances, these communities have preserved their spirit of hard work, rich art, unique culture and self-respect.

Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini said this while addressing a delegation representing various nomadic communities of Haryana and Punjab at his Chandigarh residence, Sant Kabir Kutir, on Sunday.

He said that the contribution of the bravehearts and great personalities belonging to denotified and nomadic communities occupies a distinguished place in India’s history and its glorious past.

He recalled Bhai Makhn Shah Lubana Ji, who identified Sri Guru Tegh Bahadur Ji as the true Guru, Bhai Lakh Shah Banjara Ji and Bhai Nigahia Ji, who risked everything to ensure the cremation of the sacred body of Sri Guru Tegh Bahadur Ji and Bhai Jaita Ji, who carried Guru Sahib’s sacred head from Delhi to Sri Anandpur Sahib and earned the honour of being called ‘Rangreta Guru Ka Beta’.

Saini said that skilled warriors of the Sikligar and Banjara communities strengthened the Khalsa army by making highly effective weapons for battles against the Mughals.

He also recalled Bhamashah and heroes of the Banjara community who supported Maharana Pratap’s struggle for self-respect by supplying essential provisions and material, thereby contributing to the defence of the country.

EDITORIAL

Central Asia’s Strategic Opening

Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s visit to Uzbekistan has produced an unusually substantive expansion of a relationship that has often carried greater strategic promise than economic weight. The decision by India and Uzbekistan to elevate ties to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, pursue a long-term arrangement for uranium supplies and target bilateral trade of \$5 billion by 2030 indicates that New Delhi is giving its Central Asian engagement a sharper economic and strategic purpose. The breadth of the discussions – spanning critical minerals, defence, digital infrastructure, pharmaceuticals, agriculture, energy and connectivity – is equally significant. For India, Uzbekistan is not merely another bilateral partner. Its location at the heart of Central Asia makes it important to India’s efforts to build relationships across a region where China and Russia have traditionally enjoyed considerably greater influence.

The proposed long-term uranium arrangement is perhaps the most strategically consequential element. India’s plans to expand nuclear power require reliable supplies of nuclear fuel, and diversification is essential to insulating the programme from geopolitical and supply-chain disruptions. Uzbekistan, among the world’s important uranium producers, can become a valuable component of this strategy. Cooperation on critical and strategic minerals similarly reflects the changing character of India’s foreign economic policy. Access to minerals, energy resources and resilient supply chains is increasingly inseparable from national security. Encouraging Indian companies to participate in Uzbekistan’s mining and mineral-processing sectors could therefore create a relationship that extends well beyond the traditional buyer-seller model.

The economic ambition, however, will require considerable work. Bilateral trade currently stands at only a little over \$1 billion, making the \$5-billion target by 2030 demanding. Geography remains the central obstacle. India has no direct land access to Central Asia, while political difficulties surrounding transit through Pakistan have constrained connectivity for decades. The development of alternative routes through Iran and the wider International North-South Transport Corridor consequently assumes greater importance. The two countries will also have to translate discussions on market access, banking, payments and a possible preferential trade arrangement into practical measures. A target becomes meaningful only when businesses can move goods, capital and payments efficiently.

The larger significance of the partnership lies in India’s attempt to deepen its strategic footprint in Central Asia without framing its engagement through great-power rivalry. Uzbekistan has pursued a diversified foreign policy, while India offers technology, pharmaceuticals, education, digital public infrastructure and a large market without demanding exclusive alignment. Defence co-development, counter-terrorism cooperation and stronger institutional mechanisms can add further depth. Yet implementation will determine whether the latest announcements mark a genuine transformation. India has historically enjoyed considerable goodwill in Central Asia but has struggled to convert it into sufficient economic presence. The Modi-Mirziyoyev agreements provide an opportunity to narrow that gap. If uranium cooperation, connectivity and trade ambitions move from declarations to delivery, Uzbekistan could become an important anchor for a more consequential Indian engagement with Central Asia.

LETTER



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Basic Deficits

Government schools cannot provide meaningful education when children lack safe classrooms, toilets and drinking water. Rajasthan’s infrastructure figures reveal deficiencies that deserve urgent attention beyond political confrontations. Inspections must respect student safety and established rules, but scrutiny should not be discouraged. Authorities must ensure promised funds translate into visible improvements.

GOPAL SAINI,
JAIPUR

You can also send your comments to The Editor, Millennium Post, Pratap Bhawan, 5 Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, New Delhi 110 002

Beyond the Servers

Our new India needs infrastructure for a robust digital future. But the dividend will lie not in how many servers we house, but how many lives growth impacts

TALKING SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

THE WRITER IS A JOURNALIST & COMMUNICATIONS SPECIALIST

Imagine a factory covering acres of land, drawing enough electricity to power a small city, requiring enormous cooling capacity and costing billions of dollars to build. Now imagine that, once completed, few people actually work inside it. Welcome to one of the defining factories of the AI age—the data centre. And India is preparing for these on an extraordinary scale. Its data centre footprint, estimated at 27 million sq ft in the first half of 2026, could cross 101 million sq ft by 2030. Capacity could rise from over 1.8 GW to more than 6.7 GW, backed by investments of \$300 billion.

Grand numbers, reflecting something important: they may turn India into a great digital economy. With over 950 million internet users, expanding cloud adoption, digital payments, artificial intelligence and enterprise digitisation, India clearly needs domestic digital infrastructure. But the

critical number in this story is not 101 million sq ft, 6.7 GW or \$300 billion. It is 87 million.

That is the number of Indians aged 15-29 who were outside employment, education and training in 2021, NITI Aayog’s ‘Reimagining Skilling for Viksit Bharat@2047’ report says. The category is complex, including women engaged in domestic responsibilities; it doesn’t equate with unemployment. Yet, the scale is a reminder of India’s larger challenge. The question is not whether India needs data centres. It does. The louder question is: What should India demand from them?

Hidden Appetite

Any digital economy can create the illusion of weightlessness. Data floats in a cloud. AI appears on a screen. Behind the weightlessness sits real physical infrastructure. The International Energy Agency says data centres consumed 415 terawatt-hours of electricity globally in 2024. By 2030, that could double to 945 TWh, more than Japan’s total power consumption. A typical data centre can consume as much power as 100,000 households, while the largest facilities can consume 20 times that amount.

Then comes water. Servers generate heat, and heat must be removed. Berkeley Lab estimates that American data centres consumed 66 billion litres of water in 2023, excluding the wider water footprint associated with generating their electricity. This does not make data centres undesirable. Economic development always consumes resources. The caveat is that the calculation cannot stop at investment received. It must ask what is being consumed, who bears the cost and what benefits accrue.



By 2030, India may have 101 million sq ft of data centres

THE QUESTION IS NOT HOW BIG THE DATA CENTRE FOOTPRINT BECOMES, BUT WHAT THAT EXPANSION COSTS AND CREATES

America’s Warning

That warning is already emerging in the United States. Communities that once welcomed data centres as symbols of funds and technological progress are now questioning electricity bills, water availability, noise, land use and tax concessions. Protests against data centre expansion have been reported across 42 US states. Over 100 American communities have enacted moratoriums, while hundreds of data-centre-related bills have entered state legislatures.

The lesson for India is not that America made a mistake. It is that infrastructure is easiest to regulate before dependence sets in. There is another lesson: data

centres are capital-intensive, yet light on employment. A hyper-scale facility can cover a million square feet and cost \$1 billion, but employ only about 100 people. Construction creates jobs, as do engineering, fibre, electrical equipment and maintenance. But a billion-dollar building should not automatically be mistaken for a billion-dollar employment engine. For India, that distinction is critical.

Better Bargain

India has an advantage: it is entering the explosive phase of the data centre boom while the first generation of large host markets is revealing what can go wrong. We can, therefore, build differently. A data centre approval should be viewed not as a land or investment transaction, but as a compact with its host community. How much electricity and water will it require? Will potable water be used for cooling? How much renewable power will be added? Will the operator help finance grid upgrades necessitated by its load? How many jobs will result and how many will be trained for them?

India can encourage closed-loop and low-water cooling, treated wastewater instead of

freshwater, renewable energy, transparent water-use reporting and efficiency norms. Campuses can be asked to co-invest in power, rather than leaving utilities to absorb the burden. Data centre policy can be linked to human-capital policy. If billions are invested in AI, the new ecosystem should help prepare cooling specialists, electricians, network engineers, cybersecurity professionals, technicians, green-energy workers and construction specialists the new economy will require.

This is where data centres can become more than giant rooms full of servers.

Measure Differently

Yes, India should compete for the industries of the future. Retreating from digital infrastructure would be unrealistic and desirable. For AI, cloud computing, data storage and digital services will underpin banking, healthcare, manufacturing, education, defence and government itself. But competition need not mean imitation. The next race should not be won by the country willing to offer the cheapest land, easiest water and an accommodating power supply. It should be won by one far-sighted enough to make digital infrastructure strengthen, not strain, its physical and human infrastructure.

By 2030, India may indeed have 101 million sq ft of data centres. That will make for an impressive headline. But a nation’s progress cannot ultimately be measured by how much data it can store, how many acres its servers occupy or how many investment dollars cross its borders. The most valuable capacity India can build by 2030 will still be human capacity.

Views expressed are personal

After the American Umbrella

Makkah defence pact signals shifting alliances amid growing doubts over US guarantees

STRATEGIC CURRENTS



SHANTANU MUKHARJI

THE WRITER IS A RETIRED IPS OFFICER, ADVISER NATSTRAT



The three-nation defence agreement sends a powerful strategic signal

A new mutual defence pact between Saudi Arabia, Turkiye and Pakistan was signed in the holy city of Makkah on August 7, and this has raised questions about the shifting geopolitical landscape of the Middle East, where the fallout from the US-Israel war on Iran has prompted some countries to seek new arrangements to safeguard their security. The pact has been termed the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement. Importantly, the agreement is aimed at strengthening collective deterrence against any act of aggression and stipulates that “any armed attack against any one of the three states shall be regarded as an attack against them all,” a statement from the meeting states. While it is still not clear what such an agreement might look like on the ground, analysts feel the pact points to growing questions about the durability of US security guarantees. However, it appears clear that the absence

of any visible US support for the protection and security of its Gulf allies during the Iran war has prompted this deal.

Meanwhile, reacting to the development, the Pakistani daily ‘Dawn’ says in its latest editorial that, in the midst of a gruelling war between the US and Iran, currently at a stalemate, the signing of the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement is a highly symbolic development. It comes at a time when the American defence umbrella has proved of little help in protecting Saudi Arabia and the other Gulf Arab states. Rather, the presence of US military assets in these states has pulled them into the war, as the Iranians and their regional armed allies target these facilities with ferocity and a sense of vendetta. The Pakistan Prime Minister, the Saudi Crown Prince and the Turkish President were all upbeat about the new pact, and there is a reason for this euphoria which, however, may not last eternally, and only time will

THE THREE COUNTRIES WILL HOLD THE FIRST HIGH-LEVEL MEETING UNDER THEIR NEW AGREEMENT TODAY

tell its usefulness.

Also, according to Dawn, this is not an Islamic NATO. Similar alliances have been attempted before, such as the Islamic Military Counter Terrorism Coalition, founded in 2015 and headed by former Army Chief General Raheel Sharif. It may be recalled that Pakistan-Saudi defence collaboration goes back decades, and the current pact only concretises the arrangement while also bringing Turkiye on board. But the question in many minds is what role the pact will play

vis-à-vis Iran.

It is also evident that the US has shown that it is uninterested in protecting its Gulf allies, even though the latter have purchased billions of dollars’ worth of weaponry from it. Yet, Pakistan’s defence and political establishments are optimistic that the new defence agreement can promote unity within the Muslim world instead of adding to the existing differences.

Further, the pact’s signing has raised questions about the region’s changing power dynamics. Muhammad Faisal, a security and foreign policy analyst, said the agreement’s value “lies in creating uncertainty for adversaries and strengthening collective deterrence, rather than specifying fixed military obligations similar to Western alliances”. Kamran Bokhari, a senior resident fellow at the Middle East Policy Council, based in Washington, DC, agreed that the practical shift is minimal at this stage, calling it

“a strategic signal” rather than “an operational alliance”.

Faisal further said that such statements reflect real constraints rather than diplomatic caution alone. “Turkiye does not need Pakistani nuclear protection because it is a NATO member with US nuclear weapons present on Turkish territory, while Saudi Arabia is pursuing civil nuclear cooperation with the US,” he said, adding that Pakistan’s nuclear status “matters only as implicit strategic weight”. That same ambiguity raises further questions for Islamabad. Pakistan has spent months positioned as a mediator between the US and Iran, and Bokhari believes that role could be affected following the signing of the pact.

Reacting to the agreement, Ebrahim Rezaei, a member of Iran’s National Security and Foreign Policy Commission, wrote in a social media post that “a paper agreement with Turkiye and Pakistan” will not bring Saudi Arabia security, “just as years of one-sided dependence on the Americans did not bring them security”.

Meanwhile, some Indian security experts, while assessing the implications of the pact for India, reckon that, with all three members of the new pact situated along critical maritime chokepoints and major sea lanes of communication, India has fresh reason to prioritise its naval expansion. The maritime disruptions triggered by Trump’s Iran war have already significantly highlighted the strategic importance of securing the surrounding oceans. These are some of the initial reactions in the aftermath of the pact. More in-depth analyses and assessments are expected in the near future, meriting a more detailed study.

Views expressed are personal

News at a glance

Xi Jinping reaches Kyrgyzstan to attend SCO summit

BEIJING: Chinese President Xi Jinping arrived in Kyrgyzstan on Sunday to attend the 26th Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit, scheduled for August 31-September 1.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and other leaders from the 10-member grouping are expected to participate. Xi is likely to hold bilateral meetings on the sidelines.

The visit comes ahead of the BRICS summit in New Delhi on September 12-13, which Xi is also expected to attend.

Iceland: Voters reject proposal to restart negotiations to join EU

REYKJAVIK: Icelandic voters rejected a proposal to resume European Union membership negotiations, with 52.8 per cent voting against and 47.2 per cent in favour, national broadcaster RUV reported Sunday. The referendum revived a debate shelved more than a decade ago. Opponents cited concerns over fishing rights and sovereignty, while supporters argued EU membership could bring economic stability and strengthen Iceland's ties with European neighbours amid US President Donald Trump's Greenland-related threats.

Niger mutiny: Dozens of soldiers killed or arrested

NIAMEY: Dozens of soldiers were reportedly killed or arrested after young troops attempted a mutiny in Niger's capital, Niamey, amid worsening militant violence, state television and analysts said.

The unrest centred on a military base at Diori Hamani International Airport, near the presidential palace. Russia's Africa Corps provided aerial and ground support to Nigerien forces in suppressing the rebellion. The mutiny adds pressure on the military junta, which seized power in a 2023 coup.



Flowers and Norway's flags are laid at the Palace Square in Oslo

AP

British woman fatally stabbed at train station in Germany

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Berlin, August 30

A man suspected of fatally stabbing a 31-year-old British woman with a knife early Sunday morning in the southern German town of Rosenheim was detained, authorities said.

The woman, who was attacked at the Rosenheim train station, was taken to a nearby hospital where she died due to serious injuries, Rosenheim police said.

Federal police officers, called to the scene, detained the suspect right after the stabbing.

Police identified him as a 27-year-old German man from the nearby county of Fürstentfeldbruck.

They did not release the names of the victim or the suspect in line with German privacy rules and said they were still investigating the circumstances and motive behind the crime.

They asked any witnesses to come forward and asked whether anybody had witnessed "an argument or a physical altercation" in the early hours of Saturday night into Sunday at the train station.

Train operator Deutsche Bahn, which is also in charge of the country's train stations, said later on Sunday that "our thoughts today are with the family and friends of the young woman."

Deutsche Bahn said its security personnel, who were at the crime scene together with federal police, were still in shock and would need time to process the stabbing, the German news agency dpa reported.

Train service was not significantly disrupted by the incident, police said, adding that the forensic investigation in an underpass at the station had already been completed by the time the first trains began running again early on Sunday morning.

DAMAGED WATER SYSTEMS DEEPEN CRISIS

Displaced families struggle for food, water & medicines

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Nuwakot, August 30

For thousands of people who escaped Nepal's devastating floods, the emergency has not ended. They are now living in temporary shelters, often without medicines and basic necessities they had before the waters swept through their communities.

According to a government update reported by local media, three relief camps have been established in Rasuwa and 15 in Nuwakot, while temporary accommodation has been arranged in schools and public and community buildings for about 3,500 displaced people.

The August 26 floods - which travelled downstream through the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli river system - have left a trail of destruction across northern and central Nepal, with the death toll crossing 750 on Sunday, while more than 2,500 people are still missing.

Families crowded hospitals searching for missing relatives as rescuers continued digging through mud and debris amid intermittent rainfall and renewed concerns over rising river levels.



Nepal Army personnel and local authorities prepare food for flood victims at a relief camp

PTI

NEPAL FLOODS

- » Families crowded hospitals searching for missing relatives as rescuers continued digging through mud and debris amid intermittent rainfall and renewed concerns over rising river
- » The scale of the displacement is evident from more specific local figures

The scale of the displacement is evident from more specific local figures. Nepal Police said about

1,000 displaced people were staying in nine holding centres in Nuwakot on Saturday, according to The Kathmandu Post.

Separately, the newspaper reported that about 1,000 people were staying at three displacement camps around Trishuli Hospital -- at Bhairung Secondary School, a covered

hall and Bethan Academy.

Nepal's flood shelters are facing shortages of clean water, sanitation and medicines, with pregnant women and others needing medical care among those affected. Damaged infrastructure has complicated relief efforts, while many remain missing or homeless.

Shooting at rave in Switzerland kills 1

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Geneva, August 30

A shooting at a rave in the northern Swiss canton of Aargau killed one person and left five injured early Sunday, local police and media reported. Police said they are still looking for a suspect.

"The search for the unknown perpetrator is ongoing," police wrote on X. "Possible motives and the exact circumstances of the crime remain unclear."

Cantonal police wrote on X that a 22-year-old woman

died of injuries at the scene. Four men and one woman, between 24 and 27 years old, were taken to the hospital with injuries ranging from minor to severe.

All of the victims are residents of Switzerland, police said. Their names were not released in line with Swiss privacy rules.

Police were alerted to a shooting in Aarau around 2.30am after a rave. Authorities launched a major search operation and urged residents to avoid the area.

Death toll rises to 38 from Russia's deadliest attack on Ukraine this yr

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Kyiv, August 30

The death toll from a Russian strike on a warehouse west of Kyiv, the war's deadliest attack so far this year, rose to 38 with four people still missing, President Zelenskyy said on social media Sunday.

The strike on Friday night on the warehouse -- an ammunition storage facility according to Ukrainian officials -- sparked massive explo-



sions and fires that swept through dozens of nearby homes and buildings.

Emergency workers continued to extinguish fires and identify and neutralise explosive

devices at the site in the village of Myla, Zelenskyy added. He said twenty people were injured, including two children.

Meanwhile, Russia's Defence Ministry said on Sunday it is preparing to launch "massive strikes" against Ukraine's energy infrastructure, following a Ukrainian drone campaign against a retailer dubbed "Russia's Amazon" as well as the country's oil and gas sector, which Kyiv says both funds and directly fuels

Moscow's invasion of Ukraine.

The Russian ministry described the planned attacks as a response to Kyiv's "ongoing attacks on Russia's civilian infrastructure and fuel and energy sector."

Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov vowed an "appropriate response" to Ukraine's strikes on Russian infrastructure. Russia said it downed nearly 500 Ukrainian drones, while Kyiv reported injuries.

BALUCHISTAN
Three brothers killed in IED blast

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Karachi, August 30

Three brothers were killed when their vehicle was targeted with an improvised explosive device in Pakistan's restive Balochistan province on Sunday.

The blast occurred near the Killi Bakhtair Khan area of Luni tehsil in Duki district, a senior police official.

The three brothers were killed and one of their relatives was injured when they were going to their agricultural lands in their pick-up truck, Duki Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP) Mansoor Ahmed Buzdar said, adding, the vehicle was hit by a blast caused by a remote-controlled improvised explosive device (IED) planted by unidentified militants.

The incident took place amid near-constant terrorist activities in Balochistan. Violence surged in Balochistan in July, with deaths rising 241 per cent to 372 amid security operations against insurgent groups.

QUEST TO EXPLORE HIDDEN UNIVERSE

NASA launches Roman telescope for cosmic survey

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Cape Canaveral, August 30

NASA's newest crown jewel blasted off Sunday to hunt for planets around other stars, explore secret dark energy and survey the cosmos like never before.

SpaceX launched the USD 4.3 billion Roman Space Telescope shortly after daybreak aboard a triple-the-firepower Falcon Heavy rocket from Kennedy Space Centre. Roman blazed toward an observation point 1 million

miles (1.6 million kilometres) away that's home to the Webb Space Telescope, one of NASA's other big-ticket eyes in the sky.

The bus-sized telescope -- named after the late Nancy Grace Roman, NASA's first chief astronomer -- will take more than three months to reach its destination. Once there, it will cast the widest gaze yet on the hidden parts of the universe from space, uncovering the unimaginable with unsurpassed speed. "It's going to find

“IT'S GOING TO BE ABLE TO DO THINGS THAT WE'VE NEVER BEEN ABLE TO DO BEFORE WITH ITS MASSIVE FIELD OF VIEW

thousands of supernovae, tens of thousands of planets, billions of galaxies and tens of billions of stars," said NASA science mission director Nicky Fox. "It's going to be able to do

things that we've never been able to do before with its massive field of view."

Roman's field of view is more than 100 times wider than that of NASA's Hubble Space Telescope, still churning out celestial glamour shots after 36 years in orbit. Webb joined the effort several years ago with an even narrower yet spot-on vision capable of zooming in on objects almost as old as the universe-creating Big Bang.

These three orbiting powerhouses will join

forces -- along with the European Space Agency's Euclid spacecraft and the National Science Foundation's Vera C. Rubin Observatory in Chile -- to reveal some of the universe's biggest secrets.

NASA's Roman Space Telescope will rapidly survey galaxies and discover distant planets, while helping scientists study dark matter and dark energy. Its wide-field camera is 1,000 times faster than Hubble's, promising unprecedented cosmic observations.

At least seven dead after ferry capsizes

Bodrum (Turkiye), August 30

At least seven people have died after a ferry carrying nearly 270 passengers and crew capsized off the coast of northern Cyprus on Sunday, Turkish media reported.

Some 237 people have been rescued, Northern Cyprus Prime Minister Unal Ustel told Turkish state-run TRT news channel. He said a search was underway for another 24 people.

Ustel said the ferry faced adverse weather conditions and began taking in

water just 15 minutes after departure. A call for help was issued shortly after, he said.

The catamaran-style ferry was travelling from the port of Kyrenia, also known as Girne, in the breakaway north of ethnically divided Cyprus, to the Turkish port of Tasucu in Mersin province.

Kyrenia Mayor Murat Senkul said a Filo Denizcilik ferry sank off Diana beach in northern Cyprus after taking in water about 7.5km offshore. Footage showed passengers in life jackets floating nearby. AP

MISSION SAMUDRA MANTHAN PROGRAMME

ONGC explores drillship acquisition, JV for deepwater drilling capacity

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 30

State-owned Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC) is exploring the acquisition of deepwater drillships or formation of a joint venture to secure dedicated drilling capacity as it steps up efforts to accelerate offshore exploration to find oil and gas reserves under its Mission Samudra Manthan programme.

ONGC has issued an Expression of Interest (EOI) to engage a specialist global offshore rig-broking consultant to identify potential drillship owners or counterparties, assess assets and valuations, and support the state explorer in negotiating a possible ownership or joint venture arrangement.

The initiative is aimed at creating dedicated, priority-access deepwater drillship capacity, according to the EOI issued by ONGC.

“ONGC is undertaking a structured capacity-creation programme to secure dedicated, priority-access deepwater drillship capacity in support of Mission



Samudra Manthan. In view of the same, ONGC is exploring possibilities of ownership or JV model for Drillship acquisition,” the EOI said. The Union Cabinet had last month approved Samudra Manthan, the National Offshore Exploration Scheme, with an outlay of Rs 84,084 crore through 2030-31.

The central-sector scheme is aimed at accelerating exploration of India’s offshore oil and gas resources, particularly in deepwater and ultra-deepwater areas, as the government seeks to boost domestic production and reduce import dependence.

Under the scheme, the government will provide financial support of up to 50 per cent of the cost of deepwater exploration wells, subject to a cap of Rs 675 crore per well. The programme includes drilling of 60 deepwater exploration wells, large-scale seismic surveys, development of common offshore production and evacuation infrastructure, and creation of an Oil and Gas Manufacturing and Services Zone.

To undertake such deepwater drilling, companies such as ONGC require specialised drillships. India currently does not have the manufacturing capability to

KEY POINTS

- » ONGC has issued an Expression of Interest (EOI) to engage a specialist global offshore rig-broking consultant to identify potential drillship owners
- » The initiative is aimed at creating dedicated, priority-access deepwater drillship capacity, according to the EOI issued by ONGC

build deepwater drillships, leaving explorers dependent on foreign-owned rigs typically secured through time-charter arrangements.

The proposed consultant will help ONGC identify suitable global drillship owners and contractors, undertake commercial benchmarking and technical due diligence, and assist in negotiating an ownership or JV deal.

The assignment has been structured in two phases. The first, expected to run for three months, will involve identifying, screening and shortlisting potential counterparties and establishing an indic-

ative commercial basis for ONGC to decide whether and with whom to proceed.

The second phase, which would run for up to six months from commencement, would cover ownership or JV negotiation support, documentation, financing coordination and transaction closure, including bringing the rig into India.

The consultant’s mandate would include benchmarking drillship day rates and sale-and-purchase or JV valuations against recent global transactions, coordinating technical due diligence and leading negotiations for a non-binding indicative term sheet covering equity split, governance, charter economics and an indicative sail-in timeline, according to the tender document.

For the potential transaction, ONGC is also looking at structuring a GIFT City special purpose vehicle & assessing an equity-debt funding mix, including an external commercial borrowing route, according to the EOI.

FPIs turn buyers for 2nd month in row, invest ₹30,919 crore in August

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 30

Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) infused Rs 30,919 crore in Indian equities in August, extending their buying streak to a second straight month, amid improving corporate earnings, resilient economic activity, stable rupee and easing geopolitical concerns.

The inflow follows Rs 20,200 crore invested in July, marking a sharp turnaround after four consecutive months of heavy selling.

FPIs had withdrawn Rs 49,340 crore in June, Rs 32,963 crore in May, Rs 60,847 crore in April and a massive Rs 1.17 lakh crore in March. Prior to the selling streak, they had invested Rs 22,615 crore in February, according to CDSL data.

The two straight months of buying, following the worst six-month stretch in years, offer the first indication of a possible trend reversal.

However, foreign investors remain net sellers in Indian equities in 2026, with withdrawals of Rs 2.23 lakh crore so far. This is higher than the Rs 1.66 lakh crore outflow recorded



THE INFLOW FOLLOWS RS 20,200 CR INVESTED IN JULY, MARKING A SHARP TURNAROUND AFTER FOUR CONSECUTIVE MONTHS OF HEAVY SELLING

during the entire 2025.

“The important factors driving the FPI flows into India are the reversal of the chip trade, the stability in the rupee and, more importantly, the improving earnings growth in India,” V K Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist, Geojit Investments, said.

The continuation of foreign buying in August was supported by improving domestic fundamentals as well as a relatively favourable global backdrop.

“Corporate earnings showed signs of improvement during the June quarter, helping ease concerns

around the earnings slowdown that had weighed on foreign investor sentiment earlier. Resilient economic activity and strengthening credit growth also reinforced confidence in India’s medium- to long-term growth prospects,” Himanshu Srivastava, Principal, Manager Research, Morningstar Investment Research India, said.

Global factors also turned relatively supportive during parts of the month.

Easing geopolitical concerns aided risk sentiment, while expectations of softer US interest rates and a rotation of global capital away from the crowded AI and semiconductor trade in markets such as Korea and Taiwan created room for incremental allocations towards India, he added. However, tensions in West Asia and uncertainty over crude oil prices continued to remain an overhang.

Foreign investor interest also extended to the debt market. They invested Rs 627 crore through the Fully Accessible Route (FAR) and Rs 289 crore through the Voluntary Retention Route (VRR). However, they pulled out Rs 2,318 crore through the general route.

GDP data, crude oil prices key factors to drive markets this week

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 30

Trading sentiment in the stock market this week will be largely guided by the domestic GDP data announcement, crude oil prices, and the US non-farm payrolls report, analysts said.

Besides, macroeconomic data announcements, auto sales numbers and trading activity of foreign investors would also guide movement in the market going ahead, they added.

“On the domestic front, first-quarter GDP data will be important factor for broader risk sentiment, offering greater clarity on the pace of domestic growth against the backdrop of elevated energy prices and an unresolved Middle East conflict that has disrupted global supply lines and contributed to higher commodity prices,” Ponnudi R, CEO - Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

“Markets will look ahead to the August jobs report, due September 4, along with the next inflation reading, as key data points in determining whether the recently increased expectations of a September rate hike hold or ease,” Ponnudi said.

HDFC Bank may name deputy MD Bharucha, outsider for CEO

AGENCIES
MUMBAI, August 30

HDFC Bank is likely to name Deputy Managing Director Kaizad Bharucha as one of two candidates for its next CEO, after incumbent Sashidhar Jagdishan retires at the end of his second term in October, according to people familiar with the matter.

The country’s largest private lender is also seeking an external candidate, as RBI rules require banks to submit multiple names for the CEO position. The RBI approves senior banking appointments.

Bharucha, who oversees HDFC Bank’s retail



and wholesale businesses, is among the leading internal candidates. He is not due to retire until 2029, when he will have completed 15 years as a full-time director, making him eligible to become CEO under RBI rules.

The leadership search follows six months of turbulence at the bank. Jagdishan’s retirement was announced on Saturday. He had been widely expected

to continue, before then-chairman Atanu Chakraborty resigned in March, citing concerns over practices at the bank that conflicted with his “personal values and ethics”. An external legal review found no evidence supporting those concerns.

Last month, the board penalised Jagdishan and three others in a separate matter involving the pricing of large deposits.

HDFC Bank shares have fallen 27 per cent this year, with the decline accelerating after Chakraborty’s departure. Investors have also raised concerns about limited gains from the 2023 merger with HDFC Ltd.

Top-7 cos lose ₹1.13 lakh crore in mcap

Bharti Airtel & Reliance Industries emerged as biggest laggards

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 30

The combined market valuation of seven of the top-10 most-valued firms eroded by Rs 1.13 lakh crore last week, with Bharti Airtel and Reliance Industries emerging as the biggest laggards, in-tandem with a bearish trend in equities.

Last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex declined 276.32 points, or 0.35 per cent, and the NSE Nifty dipped 76.35 points, or 0.31 per cent.

“Indian equity markets ended the week on a cautious note, extending their recent corrective phase

as concerns over global interest rates, geopolitical uncertainty and volatility surrounding the new closing auction session weighed on investor sentiment,” Ajit Mishra - SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

While Reliance Industries, Bharti Airtel, HDFC Bank, Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro, Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC), and Hindustan Unilever faced erosion from their market valuation, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, and Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) were the winners.

The valuation of

Bharti Airtel tumbled Rs 40,500.85 crore to Rs 11,74,462.30 crore.

Reliance Industries’ valuation eroded Rs 40,056.32 crore to reach Rs 17,38,119.27 crore.

The market valuation of HDFC Bank dropped Rs 11,558.35 crore to Rs 11,09,600.70 crore and that of Bajaj Finance fell Rs 10,086.05 crore to Rs 6,70,535.57 crore.

Larsen & Toubro’s market capitalisation (mcap) declined Rs 6,473.45 crore to Rs 5,55,987.49 crore and that of LIC dipped Rs 3,162.5 crore to Rs 5,32,817.81 crore.

The mcap of Hindu-

stan Unilever edged lower by Rs 1,550.73 crore to Rs 4,72,361.83 crore.

However, the mcap of TCS jumped Rs 16,643.2 crore to Rs 8,48,079.71 crore.

The valuation of ICICI Bank climbed Rs 4,475.28 crore to Rs 10,22,805.73 crore and that of State Bank of India went up Rs 599.99 crore to Rs 9,65,568.75 crore.

Reliance Industries remained the most-valued firm, followed by Bharti Airtel, HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, TCS, Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro, LIC and Hindustan Unilever.

India committed to conclude trade pact talks with Chile this year: Govt

AGENCIES
New Delhi, August 30

India is committed to concluding talks for a comprehensive economic partnership agreement (CEAP) with Chile this year to strengthen bilateral economic ties, the Commerce Ministry said on Sunday.

Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal reviewed the talks in Santiago and met Chile’s Vice-Minister Paula Estevez Weinstein on August 26.

The proposed compre-

hensive economic partnership agreement is expected to boost trade and investment while promoting cooperation in technology, talent and resilient supply chains.

Agarwal highlighted potential in healthcare, pharmaceuticals, energy, minerals, agriculture, machinery and engineering. The ministry said a successful conclusion would provide further momentum to growing bilateral trade and economic partnership.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 30

State Bank of India (SBI) and its subsidiary SBI Capital Markets Ltd together plan to dilute up to 1 per cent stake in the National Stock Exchange (NSE) through the exchange’s proposed Rs 30,000-crore IPO.

The bank is participating in the NSE IPO and will dilute a 0.65 per cent stake in the exchange, SBI Chairman C S Setty said. “We are participating in that divestment. We propose to divest



SBI Chairman C S Setty

0.65 per cent and 0.35 per cent by SBI Capital Markets because both of us hold the stake. So together, about 1 per cent as a SBI group... it could be less depending on any other shareholders

CLOSER LOOK

- » We (SBI) propose to divest 0.65 per cent and 0.35 per cent by SBI Capital Markets because both of us hold the stake. So together, about 1 per cent as a SBI group, the SBI chairman said
- » Last month, SBI, along with its foreign partner Paris-headquartered Amundi, diluted around 10% stake in SBI Mutual Fund. The Rs 9,800-crore public offer was subscribed 42 times

joining,” he said. SBI currently holds a 3.23 per cent stake in the NSE, while SBI Capital Markets owns 4.33 per cent in the country’s largest stock exchange.

He clarified that there is

no the monetisation plan for other subsidiaries in the immediate future. Last month, SBI, along with its foreign partner Paris-headquartered Amundi, diluted around 10 per cent stake in

SBI Mutual Fund. The Rs 9,800-crore public offer by the country’s biggest fund house was a huge success as the issue was subscribed 42 times.

Post-listing, SBI’s holding declined to 55.46 per cent from 61.76 per cent, while Amundi’s stake reduced to 32.56 per cent, down 3.7 per cent.

Highlighting the leadership position of SBI in the housing finance segment, Setty said the mortgage portfolio is set to cross an important milestone of

Rs 10 lakh crore in the current quarter on the back of robust demand.

The country’s largest lender had surpassed Rs 9 lakh crore home loan portfolio during the last financial year. “We should be reaching the Rs 10 trillion-mark, hopefully in this quarter itself,” he said.

SBI has a market share of nearly 28 per cent in the home loan segment, he said, adding that the bank has focused on making home loans accessible across the country.

INDIA'S FISCAL DEFICIT STOOD AT 4.4% OF GDP FOR FY26

India has met fiscal deficit target for 2025-26, says Finance Minister in US

ANI NEWS
Chicago, August 30

Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman stated that the central government has adhered to its fiscal consolidation roadmap and successfully achieved its fiscal deficit targets set for the 2025-26 period.

India's fiscal deficit stood at 4.4 per cent of the GDP for the year ended March 31, 2026. The deficit was at 15.19 trillion rupees or 97.5% of the government's revised estimates presented in February.

Addressing the Indian diaspora in Chicago, the Finance Minister addressed concerns regarding government borrowing and debt levels while outlining the nation's economic targets. "We have given ourselves a fiscal discipline path on the fiscal deficit as well. We have fulfilled the trajectory. The last mile that had to be reached by 2025-26, we have reached," Sitharaman said.

She noted that the government has established a target to reduce the debt-



Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman

THE DEFICIT WAS AT 15.19 TRILLION RUPEES OR 97.5% OF THE GOVERNMENT'S REVISED ESTIMATES PRESENTED IN FEBRUARY

to-GDP ratio to 50 per cent by 2030, contrasting India's position with several advanced economies where debt levels exceed 200 per cent of GDP.

"The trust that the world has of the fiscal prudence of Prime Minister Modi- he was so when he was Chief Minister of Gujarat, he is so now, even when he is the Prime Minister of the country, the fiscal prudence shall not be compromised.

KEY POINTS

- » Sitharaman addressed concerns regarding government borrowing and debt levels while outlining the nation's economic targets
- » "We have given ourselves a fiscal discipline path on the fiscal deficit as well. We have fulfilled the trajectory. The last mile that had to be reached by 2025-26, we have reached," the finance minister said
- » Sitharaman noted that the government has established a target to reduce the debt-to-GDP ratio to 50 per cent by 2030

As a result, credit ratings are improving," she said. The Minister emphasised that the fiscal management was accomplished without reducing funding allocated for social welfare projects or public capital expenditure on infrastructure.

Outlining India's broader economic resilience, Sitharaman pointed out that domestic economic growth has sustained a rate of 7 per cent or more fol-

lowing the COVID-19 pandemic, despite continuous global headwinds including the Russia-Ukraine war, tariff disputes, and supply disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz.

She further noted that fertiliser shortage was not felt in India because the government managed to keep the markets informed about how much it would require "The department should be given the credit for smartly arranging fertiliser from various different routes and being able to cross the current season of crops. The forthcoming season will also require fertiliser from November. We adequately stocked for it," she said.

The Minister highlighted that while international urea prices surged tenfold from Rs 300 per cent to Rs 3,000 per cent per bag after the COVID-19, the government absorbed the entire price increase by extending a subsidy of Rs 2,700 per cent per bag. In addition, when global insurance providers declined coverage for vessels navigating

volatile transit corridors, the government stepped in with budgetary support to cover the elevated risk premiums for shipping liners, ensuring import flows remained uninterrupted.

Addressing foreign trade strategy, Sitharaman explained that India continues to advance bilateral trade and investment treaties directly with partners such as the European Union, Australia, the UAE, and EFTA nations due to the slow pace of multilateral trade frameworks. "So trade agreements are continuing. On a bilateral basis, we are moving with trade treaties. The multilateral treaty age has gone off," Sitharaman stated.

Sitharaman also noted her scheduled participation in the G20 finance track meetings in Asheville, North Carolina, following bilateral economic dialogues held in Canada. She is in Chicago as part of an official nine-day visit to Canada & the US from August 25 to September 2. The US leg began on August 28.

Govt expands fertiliser tracking system to link farmers, subsidies

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 30

The government on Sunday said it is broadening a nationwide digital platform that tracks fertilizer from production to retail sale, adding tools to link purchases with individual farmers' land records and to monitor subsidy payments more closely.

The Integrated Fertilizer Management System (iFMS), run by the Department of Fertilizers with technical support from the National Informatics Centre, already tracks more than 14 crore Aadhaar-linked buyers and over 2,50,000 retailers, and processes about 70 million tonnes of fertilizer sales a year. The system underpins roughly Rs 2 lakh crore in annual fertilizer subsidies.

The department has been developing new dashboards that give officials a consolidated view of production, imports, dispatches, stocks and retail sales at the national, state, district and retailer level, aimed at flagging unusual trends or supply shortfalls earlier, an official statement said.

The Department has



also worked to integrate iFMS with farmer, land and crop databases. A pilot integration with Haryana's Meri Fasal Mera Byora programme, followed by efforts to connect with the federal AgriStack initiative, tested methods for matching fertilizer buyers with land records 'work that exposed gaps in the completeness of existing land and crop data.

Building on that work, the department has rolled out a Framework for Fertilizer Sale that links a mobile booking app to the existing point-of-sale network. Under the framework, farmers book fertilizer using an AgriStack-based ID after their land and ownership details are verified, generating a QR code that retailers scan to com-

pare requested and purchased quantities.

The framework is being introduced in phases, with the department and participating states studying booking behaviour and consumption patterns before wider rollout. Officials say the data will allow analysis of fertilizer use per hectare, by landholding size, crop and product, and of gaps between what farmers say they need and what they buy.

The department has also introduced a Vehicle Location Tracking System that links dispatch records to real-time vehicle location data, allowing officials to monitor shipments in transit and identify delays, in addition to existing tools that track goods in transit and stock levels.

Sugar prices remain firm despite govt measures to check rise

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 30

Sugar prices remained above Rs 60 per kg in most retail markets across India on Sunday, despite several steps taken by the government to check the price rise, according to official data. The Consumer Affairs Ministry data showed that the all-India average retail price of sugar was Rs 64.24/kg on Sunday, up 1.77 per cent from Rs 63.12/kg a week earlier.

The current price is 30 per cent higher than a month ago and 38.63 per cent higher than the same period last year. The MRP recorded was Rs 74 per kg,

while the minimum was Rs 40/kg, as on August 30. City-wise, retail sugar was selling at Rs 62/kg in Delhi, Rs 66/kg in Mumbai, Rs 63/kg in Chennai and Rs 68/kg in Ranchi.

Wholesale prices also stayed firm at Rs 59.73/kg, up 31 per cent month-on-month and 38.63 per cent year-on-year. price was Rs 58.66/kg a week ago.

The elevated retail and wholesale prices come even as ex-mill rates have declined nearly 20 per cent following the government's decision to allow duty-free imports of 10 lakh tonnes of raw sugar. Industry sources point out that a Rs 2-3/kg gap between ex-mill and

wholesale prices, and a Rs 7-8/kg gap between ex-mill and retail prices, is typical.

Apart from opening up imports, the government has tightened stockholding norms for bulk users and dealers, and had earlier banned sugar exports.

The Centre has blamed mills for "jacking up" prices, insisting the country holds ample sugar stocks. This is despite production for the 2025-26 marketing year (Oct-Sept) being pegged lower at 306 lakh tonnes, down from earlier estimates of 343 lakh tonnes. Annual domestic demand is estimated at around 280-285 lakh tonnes.

Comm Ministry to meet industry associations, exporters on India-US trade on September 1

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 30

The Commerce Ministry will meet with industry associations and representatives of export promotion councils on September 1 on India-US trade performance, an official said.

The meeting will be chaired by Additional Secretary in the ministry Darpan Jain. He is also the country's chief negotiator for the India-US bilateral trade agreement (BTA).

The deliberation is important as Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal will visit the US in late September to attend the G-20 Trade Ministerial



in Milwaukee and hold bilateral talks with USTR Jameson Greer. The two-day ministerial will begin on September 30. The United States holds the 2026 G20 presidency.

The official said the meeting is intended to discuss recent trade trends, the overall sector-wise performance of India-US trade, and the recent developments in bilateral trade.

Sectors expected to be represented at the meeting include pharmaceuticals, engineering, textiles, agriculture, chemicals, marine products, leather, automobiles, auto components, handicrafts, and plastics.

Industry chambers CII, FICCI, Assocham and FIEO are also likely to participate in the deliberations.

India and the US are negotiating a bilateral trade agreement. In February, both sides announced the finalisation of the framework for the first phase of the pact, but changes in the US tariff landscape have led to further negotiations between the two countries on the agreement.

Gold prices likely to face volatility in September, say analysts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 30

After a bruising week that wiped out more than Rs 6,000 from gold prices, commodity markets are heading into September with traders bracing for another bout of volatility as US jobs data and geopolitical tensions take centre-stage, analysts said.

Investors will focus on manufacturing and services PMI data from major economies, including India.

Inflation figures from Eurozone and Germany, and US non-farm payroll data due towards the end of the week will also be closely tracked, they added.

Gold futures for October delivery on the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX) tumbled Rs 6,157, or 3.8 per cent, last week to Rs 1.56 lakh per 10 grams, while silver futures for September contract plunged Rs 9,893, or 4 per cent, to Rs 2.36 lakh per kilogram.

In international markets, Comex gold futures for December delivery declined \$150.7, or 3.2 per cent, to settle the week at \$4,680.6 per ounce. Silver futures fell \$2.56, or 3.64 per cent, to \$67.78 per ounce.

Indian Bank to add 100 branches in this fiscal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Chennai, August 30

Indian Bank plans to add about 100 branches this year, with a primary focus on increasing the bank's presence in the Central and Western parts of the country.

To manage growing business and replace retiring employees, the bank would increase its headcount by about 2,500 personnel, including specialist officers.

"Last year we opened 100 branches. This year too we have similar plans. Just on August 15, which



Indian Bank MD and CEO Binod Kumar

was our foundation day, the bank inaugurated 15 branches across the country," Indian Bank MD and CEO Binod Kumar said.

The bank had 6,003 domestic branches and three overseas – Singapore, Colombo and Jaffna

and IFSC Banking Unit (IBU) at Gandhinagar as of June 30, 2026.

The seventh-biggest public sector bank enhanced its presence in the eastern region and Uttar Pradesh with the amalgamation of Allahabad Bank in 2020.

"Now we are trying to increase our presence in the Central and Western parts of the country," he said.

On the recruitment side, Kumar said, the bank would increase its headcount by 2,500 during the current fiscal. Total employees of the bank

stood at 41,875 at the end of June 30, 2026.

Asked about asset quality management, Kumar said the bank has been managing it quite well.

The bank aims to bring down gross non-performing assets (NPAs) to 1.5-1.6 per cent of the total advances and Net NPAs to 0.15-0.2 per cent by the end of the current financial year.

Besides, he said, the bank would undertake the sale of Rs 200 crore in bad loans to an asset reconstruction company (ARC) during the current financial year.

Lakshadweep: Vice Prez to launch ornamental fisheries plan today

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 30

Vice President C P Radhakrishnan will release a strategic action plan for the ornamental fisheries sector on Monday, as the government pushes to expand fish farming and exports from the Lakshadweep islands.

The plan, called 'Mission Rangeen Machhli 2031', will set uniform rules for breeding, biosecurity, quality control and trade across India's ornamental fish industry, the fisheries ministry said. The launch event in Agatti will be attended by Fisheries Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh, junior minister S P Singh Baghel, and Lakshadweep administrator Praful Khoda Patel.

India has a coastline of about 11,099 km, an exclusive economic zone of roughly 2.4 million sq km, with marine fisheries potential estimated at 5.86 million tonnes, the ministry said. The sector supports about 5 million fishers and generated seafood exports worth 738.9 billion rupees

in the fiscal year that ended in March.

Lakshadweep has an exclusive economic zone of nearly 400,000 sq km, or about 17 per cent of India's total, and has been designated a seaweed cluster under the government's broader fisheries development strategy.

According to the ministry, the islands, known for tuna species including yellowfin and skipjack, also hold strong potential for ornamental fish exports and mariculture.

'Family-linked cos cast 61.78% votes for Chandra's plan'

Their votes helped the plan secure an overall 80.814% approval in committee of creditors

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 30

Dissenting lenders have alleged that five entities linked to media baron Subhash Chandra's family together controlled 61.78 per cent of the voting share and were instrumental in pushing through his personal insolvency resolution plan, which proposes to pay just Rs 6.5 crore against admitted creditor claims of about Rs 22,006.57 crore.

The lenders contended that five entities linked

to Chandra should have been barred from voting on his repayment plan. Their votes helped the plan secure 80.814 per cent approval in the committee of creditors (CoC), according to a 144-page order of National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT). The five entities are Veena Investments Pvt Ltd, Direct Media Distribution Ventures Pvt Ltd, World Crest Advisors LLP, Lemonade Capital Advisors LLP and Corpcall Capital Advisors LLP.

The objections were

CLOSER LOOK

- » HDFC Bank, with 3.2 per cent of the total claim amount, has already said it is mulling an appeal against the NCLT's order
- » In fact, Canara Bank demanded a forensic audit, but the same could not be allowed in view of its minority voting share

rejected by Nilesh Sharma, the third member of the NCLT bench, who ruled in favour of the repayment plan after a split verdict between Judicial Member Ashok Kumar Bhardwaj and Technical Member Reena Sinha Puri.

Dissenting lenders led by HDFC Bank and IDBI Trusteeship Services, representing Edelweiss and Franklin Templeton funds, argued that the five entities fell within the definition of "associates" under the Insolvency and Bank-

ruptcy Code (IBC) and their votes should not have been counted.

HDFC Bank, with 3.2 per cent of the total claim amount, has already said it is mulling an appeal against the NCLT's order.

Other dissenting lender Canara Bank too stated that it is filing an appeal in NCLAT against the NCLT order. Canara Bank (1.60 per cent voting share) along with other public sector entities Union Bank of India (0.76 per cent voting share) and LIC Housing Finance

Ltd (6.09 per cent voting share), opposed and voted against the repayment plan submitted by Subhash Chandra for Rs 6.25 crore, Canara Bank said in a statement.

However, the repayment plan was approved by other private creditors with a majority vote of 80.81 per cent voting shares.

In fact, Canara Bank demanded a forensic audit, but the same could not be allowed in view of its minority voting share, the statement said.

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE



J&K Bank has signed three MoUs under its Corporate Salary Package (CSP) MoUs its Corporate Salary Package (CSP) with Delhi Public School (DPS) Budgam, HK Automobiles Pvt. Ltd. (HK Hyundai) and Himalayan Motors, extending customised banking benefits to 887 employees.

Briefs

Erwin boost for Mohun Bagan

KOLKATA: Scot-tish striker Lee Harry Erwin has signed a one-year contract with Mohun Bagan, and the 32-year-old is expected to join the team's training sessions from Tuesday, the club stated. The 6-foot-2 forward is known for his physical pres-ence, clinical finishing, and ability to make an impact inside the box. Erwin, who can also pose a threat from set-pieces because of his height, joins the Mari-ners after spending last season with Jor-danian club Al-Faisaly. He has represented Scotland at youth level and brings experience from spells with clubs in Europe and Asia. The striker has previ-ously played for Moth-erwell, Leeds United, Burny FC, and Trac-tor FC among others, during a career that has taken him across different leagues and countries.

No Imran Khan comments: PCB

KARACHI: The Paki-stan Cricket Board (PCB) has advised its players involved in the Test series against England not to com-ment on the issue of Imran Khan's impris-onment. This was after British media attempted to bait some of them into making comments on World Cup-winning skipper Imran's imprisonment back in the coun-try. The issue gained momentum following Sky Sports' interview with Imran's sons, aired during the lunch interval on the second day of the second Test at the Lords. Pakistan head coach Sarfaraz Ahmed was also asked whether the players had seen the interview of Imran's sons Kas-sim and Suleman to Mike Atherton.

Liverpool agrees deal with PSG

LONDON: Paris Saint-Germain forward Bradley Barcola is heading to Liverpool in one of the big-money sign-ings of the summer transfer window. The clubs have agreed to a deal worth 123 million pounds (\$166 million) for Barcola, two peo-ple with knowledge of the transaction confirmed to The Associated Press on Saturday. They con-firmed the deal on the condition of an-onymity because the details have not been made public. Neither Liverpool nor PSG have made any offi-cial comment about the transfer, which is expected to set a new record for a player leaving the French league. The deal will see Liverpool paying 106 million pounds (\$143 million) for the France interna-tional and up to an additional 17 million pounds (\$23 million) in potential add-ons. Barcola had joined PSG for 45 million euros (\$38.5 million) from Lyon in 2023.

AFTER CINCINNATI SETBACK
US Open: Djokovic remains positive

ASSOCIATED PRESS
New York, August 30

Novak Djokovic never likes to get eliminated early in a tournament. In this case, he is looking on the bright side. The 39-year-old who holds the record with 24 Grand Slam titles goes into the U.S. Open fresh off los-ing his first match at the Cincinnati Open earlier this month. That was his first action since Wimbledon, but he is at peace with the outcome.

“It gave me time to be preparing for U.S. Open in a most adequate way,” Djokovic said Saturday. “I had almost few weeks, actu-ally two weeks, to really train and get my body and mind into the right state, prepared for what’s com-ing up.”

Seeded fourth, Djokovic begins his quest for a 25th Grand Slam champion-ship – and fifth in Flushing Meadows – against 48th-ranked Mariano Navone on Sunday night inside Arthur Ashe Stadium. Despite being a sizable favorite, he is not looking past Navone.

Abhay Singh wins 13th PSA Tour title in Malaysia

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 30

Top seed Abhay Singh clinched the Tuanku Muhriz Trophy squash event, a \$15,000 PSA Chal-lenger event in Negeri Sem-bilan, Malaysia on Sunday, defeating third seed Henry Leung of Hong Kong in five games. World no. 24 Singh defeated Leung, ranked 59 in the world, 11-7 6-11 3-11 11-5 12-10 to bag his 13th PSA Tour title in 18 finals. Singh defeated the Malaysian trio of Ameeshenraj Chandaran (9/16) 7-11 11-9 11-7 11-11 3-11 in the semifinals, Md Syafiq Kamal 11-4 11-13 11-5 11-5 in the quarterfinals and Low Wa Sern 8-11 11-2 11-6 11-2 in the second round following a first-round bye en route to the final.



“Let’s see how it goes,” Djokovic said. “The opening matches are always for me, particularly in the last few years, quite challenging. So, hopefully I can overcome the first hurdle and build from there.”

Djokovic has played in just 16 tournaments this year, the fewest of anyone ranked in the top 95 on the ATP Tour. He reached the semifinals at Wimbledon before losing to Jannik Sin-ner, was out in the round of 32 at the French Open and made it to the Australian Open final, where he lost to Carlos Alcaraz.

Chelsea signs Argentina’s Emiliano Martínez

ASSOCIATED PRESS
London, August 30

Chelsea made official the signing of Argentina goal-keeper Emiliano Martínez. The English club said the 33-year-old goalkeeper, who won the World Cup in 2022, has signed a three-year deal, joining from Aston Villa.

“Coming to Chelsea, for me and my family, was an easy decision to make and I’m just over the moon. I can’t wait to get started,” Martínez said. “I want to be successful here. I’m some-one who wants to win at everything I do and I want to bring that here to this football club because it’s a football club that wins titles, so I think it’s a good match.”

Martínez is set to take over the starting goalkeep-ing spot in Xabi Alonso’s squad, which saw Robert Sánchez struggle again in

the team’s Premier League opener against Fulham. Villa earlier this month signed U.S.-born Japan goalkeeper Zion Suzuki from Parma, opening



the doors for Martínez’s departure.

Martínez has been Argentina’s regular starter since 2021, earning 67 caps. He also helped his

CLOSER LOOK

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- » That was his first action since Wimbledon, but he is at peace with the outcome
- » Seeded fourth, Djokovic begins his quest for a 25th Grand Slam championship — and fifth in Flushing Meadows — against 48th-ranked Mariano Navone on Sunday night inside Arthur Ashe Stadium. Despite being a sizable favorite, he is not looking past Navone

Feliciano Lopez as the only players to hit that milestone in men’s singles.

“I’m very proud of that,” Djokovic said. “Obviously, longevity was always one of the goals when I was younger: trying to have long career, trying to have more shots at Grand Slam and stay healthy long enough so that I can perform for as many years as possible.”

The only one he has missed since debuting in

2005 was 2017 because of a right elbow injury. He won it in 2011, 15, ‘18 and most recently in ‘23. Djokovic played his first U.S. Open match – a five-set marathon – against Gael Monfils, who is planning to retire but is also in the field at least one more time.

“Here we are 20 years later,” Djokovic said. “We’re both still grinding and representing the older generation.”

country win the Copa America in 2021 and 2024, and reach this year’s World Cup final.

Martínez won the Yas-hin Trophy, awarded to the world’s best-perform-ing goalkeeper, at the 2023 and 2024 Ballon d’Or ceremonies.

He made 256 appear-ances for Villa across six seasons and won the Europa League in May.

“I’m all passion and I play with my heart. I will give 100 per cent every game, every training ses-sion to make the club, my teammates and the sup-porters proud,” he said.

Martínez started his career in the youth squads of Argentine club Independiente and joined Arsenal in 2010, at age 17. After sev-eral loan stints, he became a regular for Arsenal in the 2019-20 season, starting the last 11 matches and win-ning the FA Cup.



East Zone’s Mohammed Shami celebrates with team-mates, in Bengaluru, Sunday

Duleep Trophy: East Zone bowl out Central

Sooryavanshi made stand-in captain for East for few overs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Bengaluru, August 30

The 15-year-old batting sen-sation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi stood in as captain for Ishan Kishan for a few overs as his side East Zone dis-missed Central Zone for 266 on the opening day of the Duleep Trophy semifinal here on Sunday.

India fast bowler Mukesh Kumar and fellow right-arm medium pacer Abhijit Sarkar scalped three wick-ets apiece to bowl out Central Zone in 80.1 overs.

East Zone captain Ishan Kishan’s decision to bowl first after winning the toss was bang on as Mukesh (3/56) and Sarkar (3/38) shared six wickets between them, while Mohammed Shami (2/42) and off-spin-ner Md Kounain Qurai-shi (2/49) picked up two wickets each to bundle out Central Zone. Kishan was, however, forced to leave the field midway the morning session after being hit on his right wrist. Sooryavanshi stood-in as East Zone’s cap-tain for around an hour on either side of lunch when Kishan was off the field to nurse the blow. Kishan later came back to take charge of the team.

When he was leading the side, Sooryavanshi also took a successful call for a Deci-sion Review System (DRS), leading to East Zone getting

a crucial wicket.

In the 40th over, opener-cum-wicketkeeper Aryan Juyal, batting on 46, poked hard outside off against Mukesh. The East Zone players went up in appeal for a caught behind dis-missal, but the on-field umpire denied that, forc-ing Sooryavanshi to trust his instincts and went for the DRS. The UltraEdge showed a small spike as the ball passed the bat, leading to Juyal’s wicket. Meanwhile, Rinku Singh (60 off 88), and opener-cum-wicketkeeper Aryan Juyal (46) were the top-scorers for Central Zone. Central Zone never got the going after being sent into bat as they lost wickets at regular intervals to lose half of their side at 125 by 45th over.

Rinku and Harsh Dubey (27) then tried to stabi-lise the innings, stitching together 55 runs for the sixth wicket to keep the momentum for Central Zone. But once Dubey was caught in plumb in front of the wicket by Qurai-shi in the 60th over, Central Zone’s innings fell apart. Saransh Jain (13) and Aryan Pandey (22) got starts but failed to capitalise. Tail-ender Yash Thakur (30 off 26) used his big-hitting skills to get Central Zone forward but the innings eventually folded inside the 300-run mark.

‘THESE ARE HAPPY TEARS...’

Federer breaks down during Hall of Fame induction



ASSOCIATED PRESS
Newport (USA), August 30

Roger Federer was brought to tears numerous times during his induction speech at the International Tennis Hall of Fame on Saturday.

As sunset crept in at Newport’s grass horse-shoe court at the entrance of the Hall, the 45-year-old Federer, dressed in a tan suit, strolled up to the stage for his speech, kissed and hugged his wife, Mirka, who had just introduced him, and realized what a chal-lenge it was going to be.

“Oh man,” were the first words from the first man ever to win 20 Grand Slam singles titles. “This is very high level and a tough act to follow.” He joked: “I don’t know if you have been prac-

ticing secretly” before prais-ing his wife’s presentation of the 272nd Hall of Famer.

Federer was inducted along with Mary Carillo, a broadcaster and former player, who was presented by Hall of Famer Billie Jean King.

Federer, called the “Swiss Maestro” during the Hall’s first red-carpet show, which began on cen-ter court about 90 min-utes before the start of the induction ceremony, told the crowd that he “was a little stressed to be honest.”

During his nearly 30-minute speech, Federer, who showed fluid move-ment and a quick approach to the net with a solid one-hand backhand that earned him a record 237 consecu-tive weeks as the world’s

No. 1 player in the ATP rankings, choked up a handful of times. It began to get tough for him about halfway through, when he talked about his childhood hero, Stefan Edberg, when he said these are “happy tears.” Then he was brought to tears again when he spoke about his longtime coach Severin Luthi, before he wanted to thank Mirka for helping him on his jour-ne-y. “Now the Mirka part,” he said, pausing before breaking into tears. “Oh gosh, this such a mess.” He tried to joke, but the tears took over like a quick return at the net.

“I need tissues and sun-glasses, everything to pro-protect me right now,” he told the crowd, fighting back more tears. But, like rally-

ing in winning one of his five consecutive U.S. Open titles from 2004-08 or reaching 10 straight Slam finals, which he won eight, Federer closed by thanking the ball boys and encour-aged players to keep tak-ing the game new levels. Federer, who celebrated his 45th birthday three weeks ago, won eight Wimble-don titles and is only one of eight men with a career Grand Slam.

DSA Executive Committee Elections conclude

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 30

The elections to the Execu-tive Committee of the Delhi Soccer Association (DSA) for the term commencing in 2026 were conducted in accordance with the DSA Constitution and Schedule III - Election Bye-Laws.

The election programme commenced on August 10, 2026, with the election scheduled for August 30, 2026. The conduct and supervision of the election process was entrusted to Justice S. P. Garg (Retd.), former Judge, Delhi High



Court, as Electoral Officer.

Following scrutiny of nominations and com-pletion of the withdrawal process, the final list of con-testing candidates (Form 6) was published on August 28, 2026. As no post/cate-gory required a contested poll, voting by secret ballot was not necessary.

Susanta Deb was elected president, Dr. Mohd Maroof Khan was elected vice-president, and Liaquat Ali was elected treasurer, all unopposed.

The following eight cand-idates were returned as Executive Committee Mem-bers without a poll: Mrinal Dhar, Vinod

Kumar, Ankita Kaur Dhu-pia, Prof. Abha Jain, Syed Jamal Nasir, Neetu Kakar, Mohd. Naem and Karan Malhotra.

The electoral process was completed in ac-cordance with the applica-ble election procedures, and the election records shall be preserved as prescribed under the DSA Election Bye-Laws.

The Electoral Officer appreciated the coopera-tion of the DSA Secretar-iat, Member Clubs, voters, candidates and all others associated with the elec-tion process.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Smt. Neelam** W/o Jaindender Chikara, R/o F-211-D, Budh Vihar, Phase-1, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 150/2012 U/s 420/468/471 IPC, PS Kanjhawala, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Smt. Neelam** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Smt. Neelam** has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Smt. Neelam in FIR No. 150/2012 U/s 420/468/471 IPC, PS Kanjhawala, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.09.2026**.

By order
Ms. Apoorv Bhardwaj
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02
Room No. 113
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/12187/RD/2026

PUBLICATION NOTICE/ C-2
IN THE HIGH COURT OF DELHI
AT NEW DELHI
(CIVIL APPELLATE JURISDICTION)
Notice Under Order V Rule 20 Code of Civil Procedure

RFA No. 462/2024 And
CIM No. 43058/2024 & 43057/2024
Appeal against the Order dated 27.04.2024
Passed by Sh. Anil Kumar Paswan, J.D., District
Judge-04(East), Karkardooma Courts, Delhi
In Suit No. 2588/16 (Old No. CS(OS) 1932/2013)
RAM BABU VERMA ...APPELLANT(S)
VERSUS
SUNITA SONI & ORS. ...RESPONDENT(S)

Notice to: Respondent(s):
6. Smt. Chanchal, W/o Sh. Sanjeev Kumar,
D/o Late Sh. Jagdish Prasad Verma,
R/o PP-11, Laxmi Nagar, 1st Floor, Opp.
Bal Niketan Public School, Near Church,
Laxmi Nagar, Delhi-110092 (M);8959657182

8. Shri Chinnu, S/o Late Smt. Anita,
(D/o Late Sh. Jagdish Prasad Verma),
R/o H. No. 193, Gali no. 1, Padam Nagar,
Sara Rohilla, Delhi-110077 (M); 9871864836

Whereas the above-noted appellant has presented an appeal under Section 96 CPC along with the above-mentioned application which was listed before the And Court on 05.11.2024 and the Court ordered issuance of notice to you, whereas it has been proved to the satisfaction of the Court that you cannot be served in the ordinary manner, Notice is hereby issued that, if you wish to defend the above-mentioned application, you may cause an appearance to be entered on your behalf either personally or through an advocate duly appointed by you for the purpose before the Court of Worthy Registrar (Appellate) on 16.09.2026 (actual) at 11:00 a.m.

If no appearance is made on your behalf, by yourself, your pleader or someone by law authorized to act for you in the above mentioned appeal and pending application on the aforementioned date, no further notice of the subsequent date of hearing of the said application will be given and the same will be heard and determined ex-parte in your absence.

Given under my hand and the seal of this Court on this 22nd day of August, 2026.
Assistant Registrar (Appl.)/Civill
for REGISTRAR GENERAL
22/08/2026



PRATIK OPENS UP ABOUT BOX OFFICE PRESSURE

He said the absence of a fixed formula is what makes the creative process interesting

What makes an actor stay relevant when audiences have endless choices? For Pratik Gandhi, the answer lies in refusing to play safe. The actor believes performers need to keep experimenting across genres and formats because the same audience that applauds them for one kind of role can reject them if they begin repeating themselves.

"Box office numbers are one of the parameters, but these are one of the parameters; it's not the only parameter. The success of the film can't be defined only by these numbers," Pratik told ANI.

The actor, known for doing theatre, films and OTT, said the absence of a fixed formula is what makes the creative process interesting. "We are in the field of experiments and we keep experimenting. I think the experiment should also be applauded equally," said Gandhi while speaking on the sidelines of Ideabazz Startup Fest 2026 at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi.

Pratik believes the changing viewing habits of audiences have also made it important to look beyond theatrical collections when judging a project. "Not all subjects need theatre. There are subjects that you see on your television; there are subjects which are more enjoyed on the smaller screen like your mobile. Each subject has a different audience, should be enjoyed differently," he said.

'THE SAME AUDIENCE WHO'S CLAPPING FOR YOU FOR A COUPLE OF THINGS THAT YOU DID SIMILARLY, THE SAME AUDIENCE WILL REJECT YOU IMMEDIATELY THE MOMENT THEY SEE YOU REPEATING YOURSELF,' HE SAYS

He believes audiences are quick to respond when an actor begins repeating a successful formula. "Otherwise, the same audience who's clapping for you for a couple of things that you did similarly, the same audience will reject you immediately the moment they see you repeating yourself," he added. AGENCIES

Sharad Shilpotsav 2.0: Showcasing India's traditional crafts



OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 30

The Development Commissioner (Handicrafts), Ministry of Textiles, Government of India, will organise 'Sharad Shilpotsav 2.0' at Dilli Haat, INA, New Delhi, from September 1 to 15, 2026.

The 15-day festival will showcase traditional handicrafts from different parts of the country, highlighting India's regional craft traditions, local techniques and the diversity of its handmade heritage. The event will be open to visitors from 11 am to 8 pm daily.

The festival will feature participation from Artisan-Led Producer Companies, enabling artisan groups to display and sell their handmade products directly to visitors. The initiative will provide participating artisans with an opportunity to engage with customers, understand market preferences and expand the reach of their products.

The event will also

IT WILL TAKE PLACE FROM SEPTEMBER 1 TO 15 & WILL BE OPEN TO VISITORS FROM 11 AM TO 8 PM DAILY

feature live craft demonstrations, allowing visitors to interact with artisans and gain an understanding of the techniques and processes involved in creating traditional handmade products.

Dilli Haat will feature specially designed stalls and installations for the festival. Along with traditional crafts, visitors will be able to explore a range of handmade and handloom products representing different regions of India.

The initiative is part of the Ministry of Textiles' efforts to provide artisans and artisan-led enterprises with greater market access while creating wider visibility for India's traditional handicrafts and craft practices.



Rajkumar Santoshi to reunite with Sunny Deol for 'Ghatak Ghus Ke Maarega'

The director-actor duo recently worked together on 'Batwara 1947'

MUMBAI: Filmmaker Rajkumar Santoshi said he is set to reunite with Sunny Deol for his upcoming action drama, 'Ghatak Ghus Ke Maarega', which he said will feature the Bollywood star in the same character as his 1990s cult action film, 'Ghatak'.

The director-actor duo worked together on the recently released partition drama 'Batwara', marking their reunion after 30 years. They delivered box-office hits in the 1990s, including 'Ghayal', 'Damini' and 'Ghatak'.



"Sunny and I are working on a few stories, and soon we will make a formal announcement about it. The film has fully fledged action. It is called 'Ghatak Ghus

Ke Maarega'. It is not a sequel. But it is the same character, like the character is from Banaras," Santoshi told PTI in an interview. The director added,

"The fans of Sunny will be happy as this new film has action, powerful dialogues and emotion. Besides this film, there are two to three more stories in the pipeline with Sunny. For instance, one movie features Sunny as a sardar in America, which is also an action-drama."

The 1996 action-drama film, 'Ghatak', narrates the story of a righteous man, who fights a ruthless gangster terrorising a community. PTI

Rishab Shetty lauds Yash in 'Toxic'

The film is directed by filmmaker Geetu Mohandas



SHETTY SAID YASH SURRENDERED HIMSELF TO A CHARACTER AND A WORLD WHICH DEMANDED A LARGER-THAN-LIFE PERFORMANCE

NEW DELHI: Filmmaker Rishab Shetty praised Yash and his latest film 'Toxic' and said the actor surrendered himself to a character and a world which demanded a larger-than-life performance.

The film is directed by Geetu Mohandas and was reportedly mounted on a budget of over Rs 500 crore. It released with dubs in Hindi, Telugu, Tamil, Malayalam and several other languages.

Shetty shared a note on his 'X' handle as he lauded the actor's performance in the film. "As an artist, when you play a character, you try to bring it to life from the bottom of your heart. And

here, I am truly impressed by the conviction with which the struggle of a powerful man has been portrayed... The effort that goes into telling a story and the journey it takes from being a thought in the mind to becoming a film on screen is humongous," he wrote.

"@TheNameIsYash sir, hats off to the way you have surrendered yourself to a character and a world that demands a larger-than-life performance. I could clearly feel that in every scene... It's not easy to give the audience an experience of how guilt multiplies and increases the toxicity in life," he added. PTI

'I have no problem with nepotism'

Arshad Warsi shared his take on the nepotism debate in Bollywood

The nepotism debate in Bollywood continues to spark conversations, with star kids often facing unwarranted trolling. Arshad Warsi, who is currently promoting his next project 'Jeevan Bheema Yojana', shared some words on the topic. The actor also credited Kangana Ranaut for bringing the topic into the spotlight.

Speaking with 'Filmigyan', Warsi said the debate didn't exist when he first entered the industry. When the host mentioned the word, the

actor said, "I have no problem with nepotism. I love nepotism."

He added, "Nepotism wasn't the topic when I came into the industry. That wasn't there at all. This is, I think, Kangana (Ranaut) is the one who came out with this idea and then it got big and everyone started talking about it."

The actor further shared, "Yes, it's there. Does it bother me? No, it doesn't. My heart tells me, at the end of the day, how talented you are; that's how far you're gonna go."

In the same conver-

THE ACTOR STATED THAT IT'S NOT 'FAIR' FOR STAR KIDS BECAUSE THEY HAVE TO 'LIVE UP TO TOO MANY EXPECTATIONS'

sation, Arshad added, "At the same time, I also know it's not easy for a star kid. It's not easy. The expectations are so high; it's like today, I see that happening with my children. The impression that other people have is that because they are my kids, they have to be good actors. But it's not the way; each one has their own personality."

He stated that it's not

'fair' for star kids because they have to 'live up to too many expectations'. He said, "The maximum anything can happen for them is a door gets opened faster than anybody else. If you are not talented, that door shuts for you." AGENCIES

